

BNM-021
Introduction to
Journalism and Digital
Media

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Journalism and Media in the Digital Age **67**

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EXPERTS COMMITTEE

Prof. K.S. Arul Selvan Director, SOJNMS - Chairperson	Prof. Pradeep Nair Department of Communication, Central University of HP, Dharamshala	Prof. Bidisha Chaudhuri IIIT Bangalore
Prof. B. P. Sanjay Former Vice-Chancellor, CUTN, Thiruvallur	Prof. Vigneshwara Illavarasan IIT Delhi, New Delhi	Prof. Subodh Kesharwani, Director, Center for Online Education, IGNOU
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Dr. Shikha Rai Associate Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU	Dr. Amit Kumar Assistant Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU	
Dr. Padmini Jain Assistant Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU	Dr. Usha Chander Research Officer, SOJNMS, IGNOU	

PROGRAMME COORDINATORS:

Prof. K.S. Arul Selvan, Dr. Shikha Rai & Dr. Amit Kumar

COURSE COORDINATOR: Prof. K.S. Arul Selvan

COURSE PREPARATION TEAM

Unit – 1	Dr. Shikha Rai, Associate Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU	Unit – 10	Dr. John Babu Koyye, Senior Assistant Professor, Department of Communication, Central University of Kashmir, Srinagar, J&K.
Unit – 2	Dr. Shikha Jhingan, Associate Professor, School of Arts and Aesthetics, JNU, New Delhi	Unit – 11	Prof. K S Arul Selvan, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Unit – 3	Prof. Anubhuti Yadav IIMC, New Delhi	Unit – 12	Prof. K S Arul Selvan, SOJNMS, IGNOU Aakriti Taneja, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Unit – 4	Dr. Archana Kumari, Associate Professor, Center for Media Studies, JNU, New Delhi	Unit – 13	Prof. K S Arul Selvan, SOJNMS, IGNOU Aakriti Taneja, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Unit – 5	Dr. Kappu Malakar, Assistant Professor, Department of Mass Communication and Journalism, Tezpur University, Tezpur	Unit – 14	Dr. Kappu Malakar, Assistant Professor, Department of Mass Communication and Journalism, Tezpur University, Tezpur
Unit – 6	Dr. Afsana Rashid, Assistant Professor, Department of Communication, University of Kashmir, Srinagar	Unit – 15	Prof. K S Arul Selvan, SOJNMS, IGNOU Madhumita Das, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Unit – 7	Prof. Nandini Lakshmikantha, Former Director, Manipal Institute of Communication, Bangalore	Unit – 16	Prof. K S Arul Selvan, SOJNMS, IGNOU Madhumita Das, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Unit – 8	Dr. Imnasena Asin, Independent Film Maker, Dimpur, Nagaland	Unit – 17	Prof. K S Arul Selvan, SOJNMS, IGNOU Garima Mishra, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Unit – 9	Prof. Nandini Lakshmikantha, Former Director, Manipal Institute of Communication, Bangalore	Unit – 18	Prof. K S Arul Selvan, SOJNMS, IGNOU Garima Mishra, SOJNMS, IGNOU

PRODUCTION TEAM

Mr. Sanjay Agarwal
Asst. Registrar
MPDD, IGNOU, New Delhi

August, 2023

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ISBN:

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Further information on the Indira Gandhi National Open University courses may be obtained from the University's office at Maidan Garhi, New Delhi.

Printed and published on behalf of the Indira Gandhi National Open University, New Delhi, by the Registrar, MPDD, IGNOU, New Delhi.

Laser Typeset by Tessa Media & Computers, C-206, A.F.E.-II, Okhla, New Delhi.

Printed at:

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COURSE INTRODUCTION

Welcome to our comprehensive **course 1 on Introduction to Journalism and Digital Media (BNM021)** for Bachelors in Journalism and Digital Media! In this program, we will embark on an enlightening journey through four key blocks. Block 1 introduces the fundamentals of media and communication processes. In Block 2, we dive into the dynamic world of journalism, exploring its nature and impact. Block 3 examines the symbiotic relationship between digital media and society. Finally, in Block 4, we tackle contemporary issues that arise in the ever-evolving landscape of digital media. Join us as we unravel the complexities and significance of media in today's interconnected world.

Throughout **Block 1, Introduction to Media and Communication**, we will cover the core topics of communication and media. In Unit 1, we delve into the intricacies of the communication process, understanding how information is transmitted and received. Unit 2 explores various communication models, providing insights into their application and limitations. Unit 3 focuses on the emergence of digital media, examining its impact on our modern world. Finally, in Unit 4, we analyse the dynamic relationship between journalism, digital media, and society, fostering a deeper understanding of their symbiotic interaction.

In this comprehensive **Block 2, Understanding Journalism**, we delve into Unit 5 to explore the nature and types of journalism, understanding its multifaceted roles in society. Unit 6 analyses the intricate relationship between technology, society, and the Fourth Estate, uncovering the media's evolving influence. Examining Unit 7, we scrutinise the crucial role of the Fourth Estate in a democratic society. Unit 8 introduces the concept of Mobile Journalism, a cutting-edge approach to reporting. Unit 9 addresses tech empowerment and the challenges faced by a muzzled press. Finally, in Unit 10, we delve into the realm of Algorithms and AI for Journalism, exploring their implications for the future of media.

In **Block 3, Digital Media and Society**, we delve into Unit 11 to explore the dynamic realm of digital media and communication, analysing its profound influence on society. Unit 12 introduces us to theories of digital communication, providing a theoretical framework to understand its complexities. Unit 13 delves into participatory culture, examining the active role of individuals in the digital landscape. Finally, in Unit 14, we study the impactful relationship between social movements and digital media, gaining insights into how technology shapes contemporary activism.

In the last **Block 4, Contemporary Issues of Digital Media**, we explore crucial topics at the intersection of technology, society, and governance. Unit 15 examines the internet's role in marginalisation and its impact on vulnerable communities. Unit 16 introduces a conceptual framework to understand digital inequality, analysing disparities in access and participation. Unit 17 delves into global communication policies, understanding how nations navigate digital communication on the international stage. Lastly, in Unit 18, we study internet governance, examining the complexities of regulating the ever-expanding digital landscape.

Through these diverse topics, we are confident that you will gain a holistic understanding of the role and responsibilities of the media system in society. Specifically, you will develop enhanced perspectives on various dimensions of digital media within contemporary social systems.

BNM-021
Introduction to Journalism
and Digital Media

Block

1

INTRODUCTION TO MEDIA AND COMMUNICATION

UNIT 1

Communication Processes **7**

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Journalism, Digital Media and Society **51**

BLOCK 1 INTRODUCTION TO MEDIA AND COMMUNICATION

This course, "Introduction to Journalism and Digital Media," will delve into the diverse spectrum of communication processes that permeate our daily lives. You will comprehensively understand the fundamental elements involved in these processes. Additionally, we will explore the crucial role of journalism and media in shaping our social environment. Moreover, you will examine the recent advancements in technology-enabled communication, which have significantly impacted our lives over the past few decades.

In **Unit 1, Introduction to Media and Communication**, we will explore the intricacies of communication processes, including various forms such as verbal, non-verbal, written, and visual communication. We'll delve into the historical growth of communications and media, understanding their impact on society and culture. Differentiating between the conventional and contemporary views of mass communication, we will examine traditional and digital media's roles in shaping our perception of reality. In addition, you will gain insights into the powerful influence of media in the social construction of reality and develop critical thinking skills for media consumption.

Unit 2, Models of Communication, explores we explore various communication models, including Shannon and Weaver's Mathematical Model, Osgood and Schramm's Models, Berlo's Model, Gerbner's Model, Newcomb's Model, Westley and Maclean's Model, and Jakobson's Model. Through a critical lens, we analyse the transmission perspective of communication and its implications in understanding the complexities of information exchange and interpretation.

Unit 3, Emergences of Digital Media, delves into defining digital media understanding its characteristics like interactivity, convergence, immediacy, archiving, and linkages. We explore the digital media landscape in India, its historical perspective, and its impact on traditional media. Emerging digital media and journalism trends, such as data-driven journalism, digital stories, and mapping, are also discussed. However, challenges like fake information, online abuse, threats, and trolling are examined to foster critical analysis of the digital media landscape.

Unit 4, Journalism, Digital Media and Society, covers the core aspects of journalism, including its concept, definitions, evolution, and changing forms. We explore journalism's challenges in the digital age and analyse the symbiotic relationship between journalism and society. Investigating the digital ecosystem's impact on media, we study digital journalism's role in empowering society and its future prospects. Through case studies, we gain insights into digital journalism's social impact and responsibilities, fostering a deeper understanding of the dynamic interplay between journalism, digital media, and society.

After completing these four units, you will understand the fundamental principles of communication processes, including how messages are exchanged among individuals and institutions. You will also explore the significant role of media institutions within diverse social contexts. Additionally, you will comprehend the rise of communication technology-based media processes in Indian contexts, expanding your knowledge of the ever-evolving media landscape.

UNIT 1 COMMUNICATION PROCESS

Structure

- 1.0 Introduction
- 1.1 Learning Outcomes
- 1.2 Need for Communication
 - 1.2.1 Communication Process
 - 1.2.2 Effective Communication
 - 1.2.3 Barriers of Communication
- 1.3 Types of Communication
- 1.4 Growth of Communications and Media
- 1.5 Communication Processes
- 1.6 Mass Communication: The Contemporary View
- 1.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 1.8 Further Readings
- 1.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

1.0 INTRODUCTION

What exactly is communication? The word is derived from the Latin word 'communis', which means 'to make common'. At the simplest level, communication involves understanding what someone conveys and means and, in turn, making someone else understand what you mean. However, for communication to occur, it is important for some basic understanding to exist, which is possible only when the two people feel and think about that subject on common lines. The more common between two people, the better their communication gets. The person who sends a message or communicates is called *the Sender/ Source*, and the one who receives it is called the *receiver*. A well-known media expert, Denis McQuail, in his book "Mass Communication Theory", defined communication as:

“The process that increases commonality but also requires elements of commonality to occur at all.”

Many social scientists have attempted to define communication from different perspectives. One of the oldest and most widely quoted ones is from a Western political scientist, Harold Lasswell (1948), who posed some questions with the answers to which would have communication defined. He described it as:

“Who says what in which channel to whom with what effect?”

Channel here stands for the medium of communication, which may be language, book or even a mass medium like radio, television or newspaper. The effect is the common understanding that communication aims at the building. According to John C. Merrill and Ralph L. Lowenstein, communication is:

“A meeting of minds, a bringing about of a common set of symbols in the minds of participants – in short, an understanding.”

1.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit, you will be able to:

- analyse communication, its process and need;
- describe forms of communication and effective communication;
- development of communications media;
- differentiate between conventional and new media, and
- interpret how the media plays a role in the social construction of reality.

1.2 NEED FOR COMMUNICATION

Communication is as important a need for all living beings as food and shelter. All living beings invariably communicate within their community, be it the birds' evening call to return to their homes, barking dogs in protest when a non-member enters their territory or the dance of the honeybees to convey to other members where nectar can be found. For human beings, too, this is a natural individual and social need, as man is a social animal. No normal human being can exist in isolation, irrespective of age, gender and interests.

1.2.1 Communication Process

Communication creates meaning shared between the participants as a continuous, cyclic process. The sender shares knowledge or information based on his experiences with the receiver. What the sender understands as an outcome of those experiences is what he further conveys to the receiver. So, one common functional definition for communication can be:

“A cyclic process of sharing of experiences between two or more participants”

This brings us to the process of communication. The process of communication involves four basic elements – the sender (S), the message (M), the channel (C) and the receiver (R) – what is also called the SMCR model of communication. The representation below (Fig.1.1) indicates how communication takes place in a cyclic process:

Encoding Interpretation Decoding (**SENDER**) Channel (language/mass media/gestures) **COMMUNICATION PROCESS** (feedback) (feedback) Decoding Interpretation Encoding (**RECEIVER**) The sender initiates communication by sending a message, and the receiver or the audience is/are the one(s) who receives it; the message is the actual content that the sender desires to convey, and the channel is the medium of conveying that message. Channel, the medium of conveying the message, can be mass media, language, gestures, body language, signs and symbols. When the sender sends a message through some channel to the receiver, the receiver decodes that message in his brain, makes meaning out of it (interpreting) and then encodes the response of that message in his mind and conveys it back to the

sender. This process of conveying back is called feedback, an important component in communication. Feedback indicates whether what has been understood is what the source/sender meant or is different from the source's understanding. While receiving the feedback, the sender becomes the receiver, and the receiver becomes the sender.

1.2.2 Effective Communication

Communication is considered effective if it produces the desired results. For example, if a political leader, through his speech, can motivate the electorate to cast their votes for him, his communication may be termed effective. A child tends to take his parents' or teachers' warnings or instructions seriously but will not listen to a stranger. His parents' communication with him is effective, but the latter is not. Both examples clearly show that the relationship between the source and the receiver communicates; this factor decides how the meaning would be interpreted at the receiver's end. The perception of the source by the receiver or the trust factor in their relationship decides how positively the receiver would respond to the source's message. Any communication is called effective if the meaning of the message interpreted by the receiver is the same as that desired by the sender. The effectiveness of the message would be clear from whether or to what extent any desired behavioural change is brought about in the receiver. This is also termed feedback, which can be in words and/or actions. *The response that a communication message emanates from the receiver is termed feedback.* Feedback may be *positive, negative or neutral*. When an employee continues to come late to the office despite repeated reminders, it is negative feedback as the communication is not getting the desired response from the employee. When a student makes all efforts to meet the assignment deadlines of a teacher, it is positive feedback as it results from the high regard the student may have towards the teacher. Hence, the teacher's communication is termed effective. When a voter does not exercise his right to vote, let alone vote in favour of or against a political leader, it is called neutral feedback, as the communication did not affect him.

1.2.3 Barriers to Communication

There are certain communication barriers which may hinder its effectiveness. These may be of varied types:

- Communicating to the receiver at a wrong/inconvenient time.
- For some reason, the message communicated is distorted (i.e., a change in the message's meaning due to noise). Noise is termed as the change introduced in the message so that its meaning does not remain what was intended by the source.
- Information overload is yet another barrier as every individual has a limited attention span during which he/she is receptive to communication messages.
- Besides technical barriers, there are also language and psychological barriers to communication. Language barriers may be of two kinds:
 - Vocabulary (use of difficult words that the receiver may not understand)
 - Semantics (when the message's meaning is unclear to the audience or

what the audience understands is different from what the source meant).

- Psychological barriers may include these factors:
- Noise: Sometimes, when the student in the class thinks of an India-Pakistan cricket match that will take place that evening, what the teacher says may be noisy. Alternatively, any disturbance in the frequency of a radio channel can create a disturbance, and the audience may be unable to hear what is being broadcast.
- Perception set differences: Over a period of time, individuals build a certain tendency to perceive a message in a certain way. For example, some people believe what advertisements claim about a certain product as their experiences with it may be positive. Alternatively, others may not believe such messages, as their experiences with the same product/service may not be satisfactory. This tendency is called the perception set. Due to differences in experiences, value systems, beliefs and social realities of individuals, differences in perception set will always exist, so a message may not have the same effect on all individuals.
- Lack of trust and jealousy may also be why a message may not have the desired effect on the audience.
- Information filtering: The receivers tend to accept only those messages that they find interesting or reinforce the notions and beliefs they already have. They filter such information and leave out the rest, becoming another psychological barrier.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Describe the process of communication.

.....

.....

.....

.....

2. Explain the barriers to communication.

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1.3 TYPES OF COMMUNICATION

Knowing what communication is, what makes it effective and what reduces its effective capacity, it is also important to know the different forms in which this process is carried out. Though we are exposed to each of these forms daily, we may have never paid any attention to them. Communication scholars agree that there are four basic forms of communication:

Interpersonal communication: This is the kind of communication in which there is only one participant, the sender and the receiver. This is also known as auto communication or introspection. Talking to oneself is a good example of this.

Interpersonal communication: This communication occurs between two participants, and the exchange may be formal or informal. It is the ideal kind of communication, as the sender can get feedback instantly. As it is one-to-one communication, the sender can also study the receiver's body language (gestures, postures, facial expressions, etc.), which gives an ample idea of what the receiver means and whether what is said is also what is meant. Influencing and persuading the other person is also easy, and there is a greater scope of appealing to the receiver emotionally by means of motivating, encouraging and coordinating. It is also known as dyadic communication.

Group communication: This is an extension of interpersonal communication, and the exchange involves more than two people, where the participants get a chance to express themselves on subjects of common interests. This communication serves many goals like collective decision-making, self-expression, and relaxation and is effective as it allows interaction directly with the receivers. One common aspect of such communication is the emergence of a leader coordinating the communication within the group.

Mass communication: This is communication that takes place with the help of a mechanical device that simultaneously multiplies messages and takes them to a large faceless audience. Mass media like newspapers, radio, television and the Internet are needed for this communication. The source and the receiver are physically separated in time and space. The audience is anonymous and heterogeneous. The feedback in mass communication is slow, weak and delayed.

Different forms of communication mentioned above are effective in different communication contexts. The widest reach is of mass communication, but the most effective is interpersonal communication. For example, to make the general public aware of a new product, advertisements and publicity are the best ways for which the use of mass media is mandatory. On the other hand, for a desired change in an individual's behaviour, like quitting smoking, it is more fruitful to counsel him personally, i.e. interpersonal communication would be more effective.

1.4 GROWTH OF COMMUNICATION AND MEDIA

When there was less communication and communication channels in society, people lived based on equality as there was no hierarchy among people.

Later, those who controlled the communication channels emerged stronger while the others were weak. With changing times and technology, the communications media developed as people realised the subtle but strong effect media could have in influencing public opinion. In earlier societies, the

number of women a man had determined his status in society. Later, the number of cattle one owned indicated one's status. Even later, it was how much land one had that determined it, and then it was the riches that counted most. These stages of societal development based on economic development are identified as:

- **Pre-agricultural societies:** Small communities existed with mostly spoken words as their means of communication and consisted of hunters and food gatherers.
- **Agricultural societies:** People practised agriculture to earn their living, writing came into being, and these were more developed societies with a complex social structure. But a huge chunk of the population remained illiterate.
- **Industrial societies:** This was the machine age and was marked by the publication of Gutenberg's Bible as early as 1455. This drastically improved the speed of book printing that was earlier copied by hand using movable metal type. Mass production became the mantra, and industrial production was centred in cities, which led to a huge migration of people from rural to urban areas. Jobs in these industries became more important than farming.

Information society: The second half of the 1900s saw the emergence of information societies, primarily in the United States. But from the second half of the century till its end, most economies of the world had drifted towards it, because of which media became much more important than before. One important invention of the time was the computer, which became the main tool for handling information, its creation, processing and distribution.

Today, information is power. Those with better information sources are more resourceful and stronger in society; they are opinion leaders and are listened to, while others do not wield such control. The information society has also seen different conventional media forms merging into one, thus becoming cheaper, more accessible and faster. The conventional media forms comprising different communication technologies merged into a computer-readable digital form. The earlier technologies were analogous or linear in nature, while digital technologies could be stored and used in any format and were easy to use. This process of merging technologies to give a better output of more than one conventional media technology is called 'convergence'. For example, a mobile phone serves the purpose of a phone and a computer as emails can be accessed on it, and the Internet can be browsed. Also, a computer acts as a television as channels can be accessed on it. Television and computers, on the other hand, have made DVD players outdated. All these examples show how the output of more than one technology can be had from a more compact and cheaper technology. Also, these technologies are interactive, making feedback an inclusive communication process. It enables the improvement of messages. This fast exchange of information through cyber networks has led to the coining of the term *information superhighway* irrespective of the communication objective, which may be social networking, e-commerce, e-governance or professional communication.

Before we delve further into this discussion of twenty-first-century technology, let us view the characteristic features of conventional media that have dominated the communication media scene for a long time and the new media that has lately emerged.

Newspapers: The ancestors of newspapers were called *Corantos*, which were news sheets published as long back as the 1620s in England and Holland with irregular periodicity. Later, around the 1640s, *Diurnals* appeared in England that were dailies publishing reports on domestic events. They were the actual ancestors of the newspapers we see today. We have two formats in which newspapers appear: *broadsheets* (for example, The Indian Express, The Times of India) and *tabloids* (for example, Mail Today and Mint). Broadsheets are the morningers that carry hard news and opinions based on them, while most tabloids are eveningers or evening papers that are more of news magazines or feature newspapers. While broadsheets come up with fresh news, tabloids carry features and detailed stories based on them. While the advantage of newspapers is that they sell cheap, they can reach out only to the literate section of the population. Over the last six to seven years, a lot of experimentation has been done in Indian newspapers, from reducing their sizes to make them portable to dividing them into as many sections as can be covered to cater to the maximum number of readers. Innovations are also brought out to market them as a product and as a viewpoint. While their circulation is dying out in the West, they are soaring high in India.

Magazines: The earliest magazine was published in England in the 1730s. Though they primarily focused on politics, they were then called *miscellanies* as they carried various contents. In the later part of the 1800s, magazines made efforts to popularise magazine reading. There was widespread growth due to increased literacy and reduced costs to ensure greater sales, and because, in that era of industrialisation, more and more businesses wanted a platform to put forth their advertisements and publicity messages. Today, magazines are generally classified into general interest and special interest magazines. The first category is those magazines that cover several subjects to cater to wider masses (for example, India Today, Outlook), and the second category is the one that caters to a niche audience (for example, Better Photography, National Geographic and Business World). Most newspaper groups own the magazines that one generally sees on the newsstands. The reason is that the newspaper's publishing capacity increases with ad flow. Newspaper groups come up with sister concerns in the form of magazines that have a longer shelf life and hence make advertisement publication a costlier affair.

Radio: Radio was first invented by an Italian named Marconi in the 1890s. He is called the 'Father of Radio'. Broadcasting, or transmitting voices and music to a geographically separated large audience, had begun through the telephone, invented by Alexander Graham Bell before the advent of radio. That is when radio became a mass medium. The first licence for transmitting a broadcast in India was given in February 1922, while the AIR was formed in June 1936. The most important time in the history of radio was during the Second World War when this medium of addressing the masses became immensely significant. This was because the Nazis in Germany used it for

propaganda, and by playing German music which would give an impression that they had conquered the areas where the music was played, they could damage the morale of their rival forces. FM broadcasts started in Chennai (then Madras) in 1977 and Jalandhar (Punjab) in 1992. Private players came into the picture only in 1993. Radio later developed into a youth medium. Today, radio's approach is more local, from updating traffic to playing popular music. The advantage of this medium is that it is mobile, does not require reading ability and can be enjoyed without demanding sole attention on the medium itself (unlike television). These days, the emergence of community radio is seen in large numbers, which makes more specialised programmes for a niche audience.

Television: Television first started developing in the 1920s and 1930s. After the printing press, television is considered to be the most important communication invention. By the late 1940s and early 1950s, television had become a part of life in most of the developed countries. In India, television was introduced to bring about development in the year 1959. By 1970, the content on TV included news, information and entertainment programmes, including 'Krishi Darshan', which began in January 1967 for farmers in 80 villages. Commercials were first telecast in January 1976. Today, the number of television channels in India outnumbers the time one can afford to watch them, even once a week. The race for TRPs (Television Rating Points), which decide the popularity of a TV show or a channel, is of prime importance as it directly affects the channel's ad revenue. In fact, for that very reason, channels do not mind compromising on work ethics or building an agenda for public discussion for their vested interests. 24-hour news channels have become a reality with no sanctity of what should be called news. Television creates a reality that may sometimes not be real. For example, the portrayal of superwomen in Indian media- one who can single-handedly carry out all personal, professional and social tasks without faltering at any time- is the ideal modern Indian woman.

Cinema: The earliest cinema portrayed real event shots in motion without any sound, storyline or plot. They were just black and white, larger-than-life-size silent scenes that first appeared as early as 1896. The first Indian movie is said to be '*Raja Harishchandra*', a silent movie made in 1913 by one of the pioneers of Indian cinema, Dadasaheb Phalke. The first talkie (a film that could talk) in India was *Alam Ara*, made in 1931. In the years to come, regional cinema also flourished. Contemporary films have not just remained a form of art for its lovers to delight in; they have also started taking up contemporary issues, making for entertainment and food for thought. The relationship of cinema with society is very complex. It has been found to have an effect on the psychology of the audience.

In contrast, the degree of audience acceptability has varied from one film to another, looking at their experimental nature and low investments over the past four to five years. While romance, comedy and depiction of real-life situations click with the audience, most of the time, horror films are much less accepted. The Central Board of Film Certification in India looks into what can go to the larger masses and what may disturb their sensibilities. Following a certain 'Code of Ethics,' they either allow or censor objectionable

scenes in a film. Also, based on whether they can affect the minds of the more impressionable section of society, the films are certified as 'U' or universal (meant for all age groups) and 'A' or adult (meant for people only above 18).

Folk media: This medium has been alive in our society since ancient times and has been used for conveying political, social and moral messages. The advantage of such a medium is that it is personalised (members of the same community perform it) and is used where the audience fully accepts it, which makes the communication effective. It relates to all age groups of people and is inexpensive. Mainly confined to rural India, this is special in every part of the country. For example, Tamasha and Pawala in Maharashtra, Yakshagana in Karnataka, Jatra in Bengal, Bhavai in Gujarat and Nautanki, Ramlila and Raslila in the northern states of India. Sometimes, their messages may be satirical or sharp, but they are efficient communication tools. Many NGOs also use these forms, considering how powerful a medium it is. Government bodies in rural areas also use folk media to pass on health agriculture or any other development issue-related messages that are smartly imbibed in traditional folk songs, dances and mythological stories. That is what makes it a powerful tool for development communication.

So far, we discussed conventional media; the new media is the Internet. Let's see how it has revolutionised the world.

Internet: The first calculator, the 'abacus', was the predecessor of the computer, which was first used by Egyptians in 460 BC. Some scholars also mention the Chinese abacus. Charles Babbage, an Englishman, is called the father of computers who first produced designs for a computer that could make calculations based on stored memory. The Internet as we know it today has fast developed to replace and merge most communication devices and technologies. Today, they are used in educational institutions, commercial and business organisations, government departments, international organisations and the defence sector. But these are the major sectors; it has made its inroads even into most individuals' lives and given them an internet identity. Virtual reality has almost become literal with the kind of involvement it has in our day-to-day lives. It has the most evident advantages but also perils that stand out. While social networking has helped build interpersonal connections in far and distant lands for personal and professional reasons without spending as much as a penny, it has also led to anti-social and aggressive behaviour on the net. For example, writing hate mail about personalities, organisations and religions, defaming and harassing people by posting morphed photographs or posting nasty things by hacking their accounts and different kinds of cyber crimes like hacking bank accounts and even child molesters contacting children through chat rooms. Whatever its dangers, the Internet has taken the world by storm, and there is no stopping it.

Moreover, as referred to earlier, each conventional medium has computer-related technology to operate it. As all TV and radio have turned to digital analogous, printing has become cheaper with the aid of computers in the form of desktop printing. Newspapers and magazines use computers for designing

and editing; e-books and e-musics are available at the click of a mouse, and films and videos use this technology, too.

So far, we have understood what mass communication means, how mass media developed, and the special features and characteristics of different media forms, both conventional and new media. Now, let us analyse the conventional and contemporary views of mass media.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are the different types of communication?

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2. Information is power-elaborate.

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3. Identify the different media categories.

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1.5 COMMUNICATION PROCESSES

To make the study of the conventional and contemporary view simple, let us try to analyse communication through its characteristics and economics.

Conventional Communication characteristics: The conventional view of mass communication considers media all-powerful. The communication was made from a single source to anonymous and heterogeneous multitudes of audiences irrespective of their tastes, interests and preferences. The audience was considered passive and would accept anything served to them by the media. Through their media empires, a few media controllers decided what should and should not go into the public domain or what should be the public agenda; they were instrumental in creating the tastes and opinions of the audiences. So, they acted as gatekeepers in the media and helped set the media's agenda. These functions are called the *gatekeeping and agenda-setting* functions of media, respectively. While the messages were undifferentiated (i.e. same for all audiences alike), the motive was to create

some kind of consensus among all by creating similar tastes and viewpoints. The feedback to such communication was negligible and was not given much importance.

Conventional media economics: Alongside these characteristics, media economics also toed a different line. You all know that the media get their revenues from advertising. The larger the circulation of newspapers and the greater the television rating points (TRPs) for television channels, the more profitable the business will be. In such a conventional system, media required as many audiences as they could possibly get to generate revenue through advertising. The audience was not systematically targeted as it was not differentiated according to market needs.

1.6 MASS COMMUNICATION: THE CONTEMPORARY VIEW

Contemporary Communication: Convergence has been phenomenal in defining the contemporary view of mass communication as we know it today. Convergence is the phenomenon of merging technologies and producing more than one different kind of output while also making its use simpler. Convergence, along with further technological innovations, made the media market consumer-oriented. With the onset of 24-hour news channels and numerous entertainment channels, more magazines and newspapers, and more FM channels on the radio, there was a huge variety of content for the consumer to pick and choose from. There was something for all audience segments, whether homemakers, children, adults or people looking for serious news and opinions. This gave the media consumers the liberty to form their own opinions and created competition among various media platforms (inter-media competition like that between print and electronic media) as well as the media groups owning similar media segments (intra-media competition like between different newspapers).

Meanwhile, control shifted into the hands of the consumer, who became spoilt for choice and wielded control by simply zapping channels or choosing to change the newspaper that came to his house. While technology became an easy-to-use product, consumers also found themselves becoming the producers of content. For example, they could now create their websites or blogs, create their movies and upload them for everyone to see. Citizen journalism is another case in point. As they were the producers and consumers of media communication, they came to be called prosumers.

Media economics: There was a greater focus on media marketing innovations, with media enticing the audience with various ways to opt for their product. A price war ensued between media organisations, and every media tried to slash their prices as much as possible while aiming to build on their circulation/TRPs. Every medium started marketing itself like any other usable commodity, say, soap or shampoos. Media also collaborate with products or services other than media to sell themselves. Most organisations wanted to own more media platforms; for example, a newspaper owned a radio, TV, event management, and news agency. This benefited in creating monopolies in their markets and helped create a self-sufficient support

system for all their media platforms. But what was more, they were better positioned to negotiate with their advertisers with better offers and packages. Today's media companies are ready to pirouette as per audience demands and encourage audience participation and feedback while aiming for profit maximisation.

1.7 LET US SUM UP

Media never promised to work for philanthropy, though they were created to be socially responsible. It remained on us, the audience, to stay aware of the kind of content it offered and select/ reject it collectively. Initially, the country's statesmen wanted to see the media strong on national and regional levels, as their planned objectives differed. But once this entity became powerful, it diverted its focus to suit its needs. Now, society looks for someone with whom the buck would rest. But, the truth is that nobody can/will solely shoulder the responsibility. Only the audience denouncing malpractices of the media and introducing a synthetic value system in Indian society can change what is being served to the audience in the name of news, entertainment and role models. Change always takes longer and is always challenging. The future holds hope. What remains to be seen is whether or not our media with the people would be able to meet the challenge.

1.8 FURTHER READINGS

Books:

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1.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The sender sends the message to a receiver through a channel. Feedback is called feedback when the receiver transmits his reaction to the sender. The communication can be verbal or non-verbal.
2. The barriers to effective communication are Inconvenient timing, information overload,

Check Your Progress 2

1. The different types of communication are intra-personal, interpersonal, group and mass communication.
2. People with better sources of information are more resourceful, rich and strong in any society. They wield power and control. Others respect them.
3. The conventional media are newspapers, magazines, radio, television, cinema, and folk media. The new media are internet-based media platforms. The other classifications are Print media- newspapers and magazines; electronic media- radio and television; and folk media and new media. Often, films fall into their own category.

UNIT 2 MODELS OF COMMUNICATION

Structure

- 2.0 Introduction
- 2.1 Learning Outcomes
- 2.2 Communication Models
- 2.3 Shannon and Weaver's Mathematical Model
- 2.4 Osgood and Schramm's Models
- 2.5 Berlo's Model
- 2.6 Gerbner's Model
- 2.7 Newcomb's Model
- 2.8 Westley and Maclean's Model
- 2.9 Jakobson's Model
- 2.10 A Critique of Transmission Perspective
- 2.11 Let Us Sum Up
- 2.12 Keywords
- 2.13 Further Readings
- 2.14 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

2.0 INTRODUCTION

In this unit, we will study various models of communication. With their help, we will try to understand the communication process with multiple steps and stages. We will start with basic communication models and then move to the more complex ones. Along with them, we will uncover various concepts of noise, feedback, context, shared experience and equilibrium.

We will further discuss how these concepts affect and impact the communication process and the effectiveness of a message. Towards the end of the unit, we will critique the perspective adopted by these models and explore other ways of understanding the process of communication from different angles.

2.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completing this model, you should be able to:

- explain why we need models to understand communication; describe the basic and more complex models;
- discuss how these models are relevant in the contemporary social and media environment;
- Enumerate the basic elements that are an essential requirement (SMCR) for communication and understand the interrelationship between these different elements;

- explain how these models can be applied to interpersonal communication and which of these models is helpful to understand mass communication better; and
- understand and critique the notion of ‘transmission perspective’ in communication models.

2.2 COMMUNICATION MODELS

Communication is a complex process involving many stages, many participants, and the formation and consumption of a message. Communication studies use communication Models to understand and discuss the process of communication. Now the question arises: why communication models?

Models visualise the process of communication. In other words, we can understand the communication process by representing it in a graphic form. Models are thus abstractions of larger and more complex processes and ideas of communication. They should be seen as maps that guide us to understand human and technology-driven communication better. Some models are more detailed than others, while others are more basic and rudimentary. As communication studies as a paradigm evolved, so did the attempts at learning and depicting the process.

According to **Harold Lasswell** (1948), a convenient way to describe an act of communication is to answer these questions:

- Who
- Says what
- In which channel To whom
- With what effect

If we focus on this model carefully, we can observe that the emphasis has been placed on the effect of communication on the receiver. The whole process is understood as a means of creating an effect on the receiver by ‘transmitting’ some information. The result judges its quality and whether the message was accepted favourably. Let us look at some other variations of transmission models.

2.3 SHANNON AND WEAVER’S MATHEMATICAL MODEL

Our journey began at the Bell Telephone Laboratories, where Shannon and Weaver worked on the mathematical communication model. They were not social science researchers but engineers working on the process of communication. Let us look at this model as given in Figure 1:

In this linear model of communication, Shannon and Weaver have tried to understand and describe the communication process by taking cues from the telephone system. Their main concern is looking for the most efficient way to use a communication channel to transmit the maximum amount of information from the source to the destination.

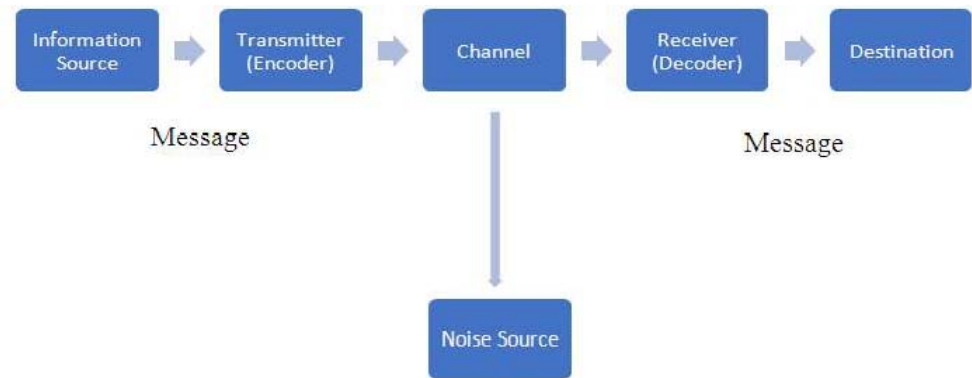


Fig. 1

In this communication process, the message that originates with the source is transformed into a signal by the transmitter; this signal is then sent across to the receiver through the channel and finally reaches the destination. In a telephone system, the channel is the telephone cable, the signal is the electric current, and the transmitter and receiver are the telephone instruments. Because of how this model has been conceptualised, it is also known as the engineering communication model. According to John Fiske, Shannon and Weaver's mathematical understanding of communication is based on the premise that accuracy and efficiency are the key concerns for effective communication. In doing so, Shannon and Weaver assumed that efficient communication could best convey desired meaning or enable semantic accuracy.

The most important aspect of Shannon and Weaver's model is the concept of **noise**, which can hinder the process of effective communication. "Noise is something that gets added to the signal between its transmission and reception that is not intended by the source" (Fiske: 1982). In other words, noise is an unwanted signal that gets added and hinders the transmission of the intended message, making decoding the message much harder. This hindrance could be in the form of physical noise, like a booming microphone, a noisy ceiling fan, a blaring loudspeaker or just static in the telephone connection.

But there are other ways in which we can conceptualise noise. Semantic noise would occur even when the transmission of the message is accurate and efficient but cannot transmit the intended meaning. Can you think of real-world examples where someone says something eloquently but is misread by the intended audience? Shannon and Weaver also argued that there could be three levels of problems in this suggested model of communication:

- **The technical problem:** Where there is a problem in the channel or decoding. This will affect the accuracy of the message. For example, if the pages of this book are torn, or the ink is illegible, you may not understand what is written.
- **The semantic problem:** There is a discrepancy in the meaning the receiver understands. For example, reading and comprehending this text would be impossible if you do not understand English.
- **The effectivity problem:** There is a question of the message being received and comprehended but still ineffective. Many social messages fail to work as they do not bring about the intended change in the audience's

behaviour. Going by the same analogy again, if you find this text boring, you may not learn anything, which is the intended result of this book.

2.4 OSGOOD AND SCHRAMM'S MODEL

Charles E. Osgood (1954) developed a model in which the sender and the receiver enter into a dynamic relationship with each other in the communication process. According to them, the process is equally important and bilateral instead of unilateral.

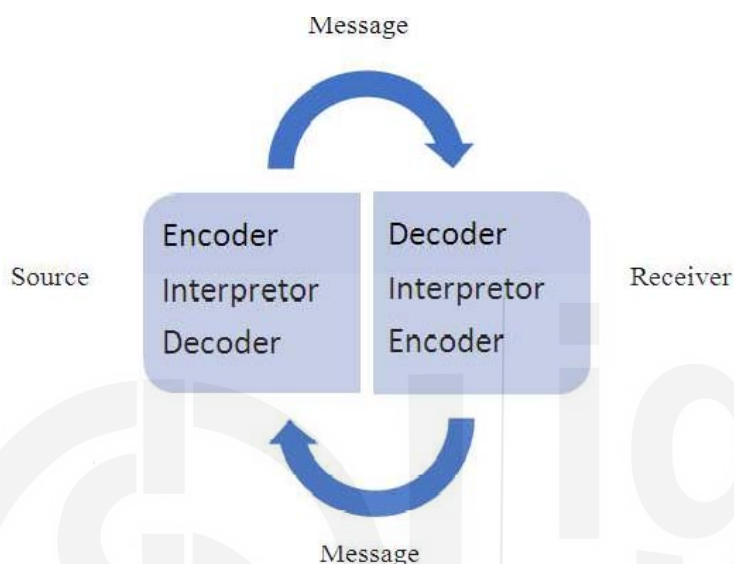


Fig. 2

In this model, the source or the sender encodes a message decoded and interpreted by the receiver. But the process does not end here. Now, it is the receiver's turn to encode a message and send it to the source. This message is now decoded and interpreted by the source. The strength of this model is that it looks at communication as a far more dynamic and interactive process in which both the source and receiver, A and B, participate by responding to each other and picking up cues from each other. **Wilbur Schramm** (1971) further elaborated on the idea of the processual nature of communication. He added another significant element to the communication process: **feedback**.

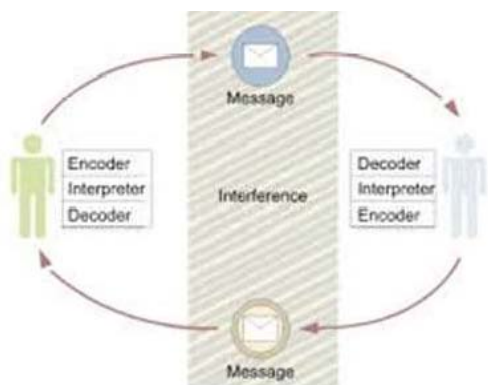


Fig. 3

So when A converses with B, the following chain of events occurs: A encodes a message and sends it through a channel. B receives the message, decodes it

and responds by sending his *feedback*. This feedback can be in the form of a gesture, a word, or even a long sentence. The sender will be able to understand the effectiveness of his message with the help of feedback, which would lead to better communication. The feedback element makes Schramm's model reciprocal and highly interactive. Schramm states, "It is misleading to think the communication process starts somewhere and ends somewhere. It is really continuous."

Schramm also emphasised that the source begins with pictures in his head, but these cannot be transmitted unless encoded into **signs** for transmission.

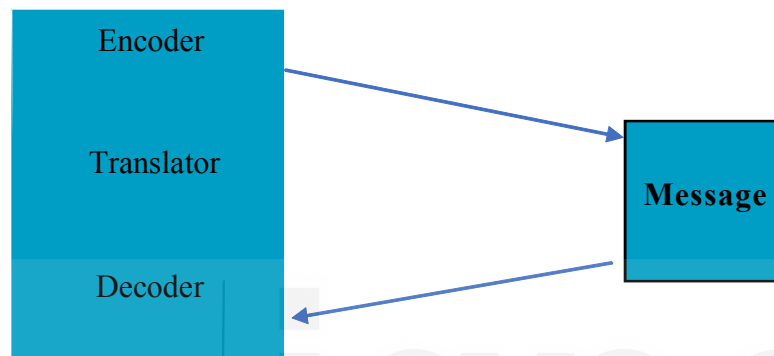


Fig. 4

So, the first stage is encoding the message in words or other symbols. Once encoded, the message is free of the sender. In other words, the sender has no control over the message. Even before we consider the effectiveness of the message, we need to consider whether the message will bring out the desired meaning. For this, the message has to be decoded by the receiver.

According to Wilber Schramm, the critical question is, "whether the picture in the head' of the receiver will bear any remembrance of that in the head of the sender. '. In other words, the receiver and the sender have to be in tune with each other. This is similar to the need for a radio transmitter and receiver to be on the same frequency for transmitting the signal.

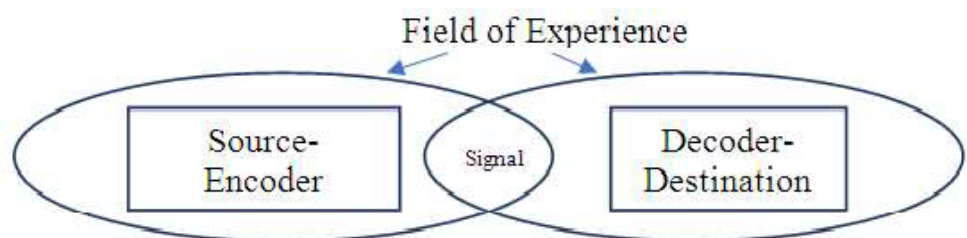


Fig.5

In this model, Schramm introduces the concept of the field of experience, which is vital for communication to occur. These fields are nothing but peripheries of a person's total human experience. If both the source and receiver are intune with each other, then the signal will be within the circles of accumulated experience of the two individuals. In such a case, the communication process will be able to deliver the intended message.

Let us go back to the example of using the word Lift instead of the word Elevator. The sender will encode the message according to her experience. So

communication will be difficult if the word Lift is used and the receiver is unfamiliar with it in the context in which the sender uses it. The problem here is that the Lift is not part of the receiver's field of experience. He/she is more used to the word Elevator. Thus, while selecting words, signs or symbols to encode a message, the sender keeps the receiver's experience in mind. This example can also be used to understand the concept of semantic noise.

2.5 BERLO'S MODEL

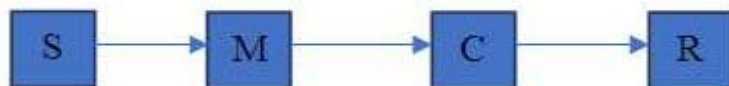


Fig. 6

As Berlo suggested, this model lists four essential elements involved in the communication process. The source (S) is the originator of the message (M), which needs a channel (C) for it to reach the receiver (R). Again, the communication process is seen as a linear chain of events geared towards transmitting a message to the receiver. The source, the originator of the entire communication process, drafts a message according to his skills and opinions, which is transmitted through a channel to reach out to the receiver.

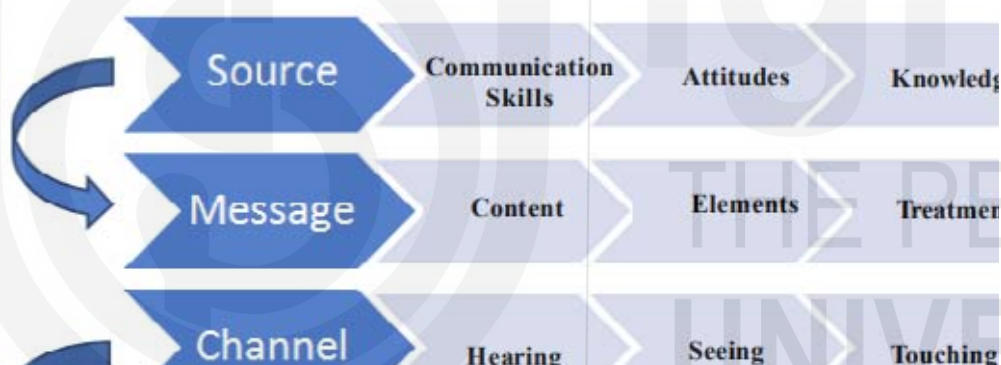


Fig. 7: A source encodes a message for a channel to a receiver who decodes the message: S-M-C-R Model

In Berlo's model, the source encodes the message according to his communication skills, knowledge, attitude and social and cultural values. The message itself has been understood with the help of various categories like its content, treatment and structure. The channel can be as diverse as hearing, touching, seeing, tasting and smelling. Finally, the receiver decodes the message according to his/her knowledge, communication skills and attitudes.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What is semantic noise?

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2. What is the role of feedback in Osgood and Schramm's communication model?

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2.6 GERBNER'S MODEL

George Gerbner's model brings another dimension to our understanding of communication. That is the dimension of perception and meaning. By doing so, Gerbner clearly distinguishes between 'reality' and the message that shapes this 'reality'. According to Gerbner, the communication process has two dimensions – the perceptual and the communicating or means and control dimension.



Fig. 8

The process in this model begins with an event E, something in external reality perceived as M (M can be a human or a machine such as a camera). M's perception of E results in E1. This is the perceptual dimension at the start of the process. The relationship between E and E1 involves selection. M cannot possibly perceive the whole complexity of E. If M is a machine, this selection is determined by its engineering or physical capabilities. But if M is human, the selection is made through interaction and negotiation. In other words, an individual tries to match the external stimuli with internal thought patterns to arrive at some perception of the event. This process involves the social and cultural experience of the individual. M brings into the process of perception his own experience and point of view. This also means that different people will perceive the event E differently.

In the second stage in this model, which is the vertical dimension, E1 turns into a signal or SE (signal about the event). This is in the form of a message or a statement about the Event or E. SE includes S, the form and shape of the message, as well as E, or the content of the message. In this vertical dimension, selecting the medium or channel of communication is important. This selection process required M to have some control over the media or channels of communication. Just as E1 can never be a complete response to E, similarly, SE can never be a complete and comprehensive response to E1. There are bound to be some distortions or exclusions.

In the third stage, we return to the horizontal dimension again. In this, the receiver or M2 is making a perception of SE. Once again, the receiver (M2) perceives SE through interaction and negotiation. M2 brings to SE his own needs and his social and cultural experience and finds meaning in the message

accordingly to turn it into SE1.

What is important about Gerbner's model is that reality and our perception of reality are distinct. That is why there is a difference between E the event and the percept E1. Similarly, there is a difference between the message SE and how the receiver perceives it as SE1.

Activity- 1

The Metro Rail will make its first-ever trip in your neighbourhood, connecting it to the other parts of the mega city. How will you apply Gerbner's model to this event?

2.7 NEWCOMB'S MODEL

Newcomb's model is shaped like a triangle, and its importance lies in how it introduces us to communication's role in society. For New Comb, this role is to maintain equilibrium in society.

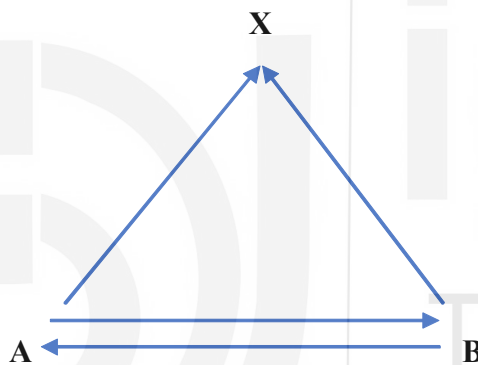


Fig. 9

In this model, A and B are the communicator and receiver. They may be individuals or organisations or a Government and its people. X is part of their social environment. ABX thus becomes a system, which means its internal relations are interdependent. In this ABX system, if A changes, B and X will also change; if A changes his relationship to X, B will have to change its relationship with X or A. The ABX system will be in equilibrium only if A and B have similar attitudes towards X. The more important a place X has in A and B's social environment, the more urgent their need to communicate and share a common orientation towards X will be.

For example, if A is the Government, B is an organisation representing financial institutions, and X is the economy. During the economic recession, A and B will have to communicate more with each other because it concerns them both in a significant way. Similarly, during the war, more communication and sharing of information are required between A, the Government, and B, the people over X, which is the War.

What is important about Newcomb's model is its concern with those social situations which trigger the need for more communication. Secondly, Newcomb's model concerns broader orientations and attitudes towards X in the ABX system between A and B. Communication plays a crucial role in giving information about our

2.8 WESTLEY AND MACLEAN'S MODEL

This model, designed by Westley and Maclean in 1957, is important for our understanding of mass media like newspapers, radio and television. This model is also understood as extending Newcomb's model by introducing C as the new element in the ABX system. C acts as a filtering mechanism that decides what and how to communicate. Here is what the model looks like.

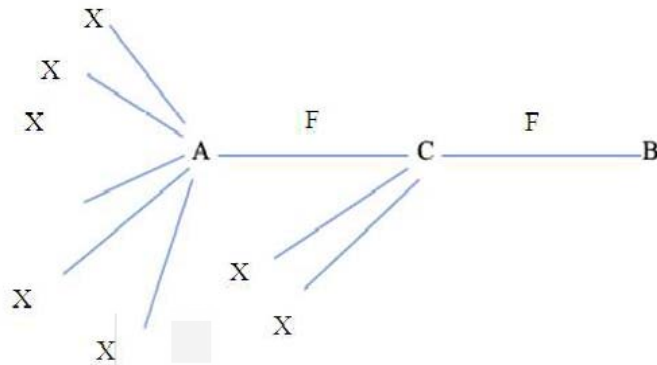


Fig. 10

X = source of information
A = Sender
C = Gatekeeper B = Audience
F = Feedback

In this model, A is the sender, and B is the receiver or the audience. A relies on various sources (X) for information. Thus, X, or the social environment, is closer to A than to B in this model. The arrows are now one way, as in earlier linear models. What is significant about this model is the diverse nature of X, accessed by A. A reporter writes her story through her interactions with X at various levels, depicted as X1, X2, X3, X4 and so on.

Interestingly, X can be interpreted in its plurality, representing several voices and events, thus providing several options for selection and negotiation to A. Thus, mass media are extending the social environment (X) to be accessed by A, which B needs to relate to. But B has no direct contact with X. C acts as the Gatekeeper and decides which information A has provided should ultimately reach the audience.

We can take the example of a newspaper reporter, A, who sends a story to her editor, C, to get published in the newspaper. The editor may use the story in a modified manner or take it as it is. It is also possible that the editor will not use the story at all. So, the editor or C, as shown in Figure 10, acts as a filter. After going through this filtering process, the message reaches B or the audience. B is very much at the mercy of both A and C. Even in terms of feedback, C acts as a filtering mechanism. The audience here is seen as dependent on mass media for information, while the means to satisfy this need for information is severely restricted through the process of selection as carried out by A and the process of gatekeeping carried out by C.

According to Dennis McQuail, Westley and Maclean's model is important since it asserts that "mass communicators do not originate messages or communication. Rather they relay to a potential audience their account (news) of a selection of events occurring in the environment." This selection is made based on assessing what the audience might find interesting.

Activity – 2

A reporter working for a daily newspaper is sent to a temple town where several people have lost their lives in a stampede at the temple site. Apply the gatekeeping model and show how the news will reach the reader in this situation, considering all the actors involved as envisaged in this model.

Even though this model is helpful for mass media like newspapers, it would work equally well for television and the internet or can be applied to film festivals, cultural festivals and diverse media forms like the animation industry. In the case of a film festival, a festival coordinator may receive several films to be considered for screening at a film festival. The curators of the festivals will have to undergo a process of selection and elimination to select a certain number of films. That can be shown at the festival. They may set up the guidelines for the selection criteria according to the theme and the festival's focus.

Westley and Maclean's model can thus be applied to various media technologies and networks. However, the model is not concerned with the criteria for selection and elimination. It does not tell us on what grounds the gatekeeping process takes place, but it makes us aware of the role of gatekeepers in mass media.

2.9 JAKOBSON'S MODEL

This model draws from both linear and triangular models. Jakobson was a linguist and, therefore, framed his model on questions of meaning and the internal structure of a message. The importance of this lies in the fact that it moves far beyond the transmission perspective in communication. The model gives importance to the context and the codes involved in communication. The model enumerates six factors of communication with six corresponding functions.

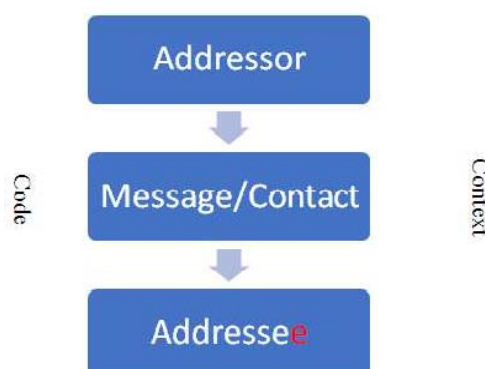


Fig. 11

The (1) **address or** sends a (2) **message** to the (3) **addressee**. The message requires a (4) **context to be effective**, which performs the referential function. The other factor is the (5) **contact**, which keeps the physical and psychological connections between the addressor and the addressee open. The

last element is the (6) **code** shared by the addressor and the addressee. Each of these elements performs an important corresponding function in verbal communication.

Code	Metalingual	It points towards the genre or the nature of the interaction.
Addressee	Conative	It persuades or influences the addressee according to the desired goal.

According to this model, each factor is essential for communication but not all the six functions must be equally important. A communication event may give importance to only one or more functions. For example, if the poetic function is given importance, other functions, such as the referential function, may become dormant. In other cases, the emotive function may take precedence over the other functions.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Explain how gatekeeping affects the process of communication.

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2. Identify the six functions of communication listed in Jakobson's model.

.....

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.....

2.10 A CRITIQUE OF THE TRANSMISSION PERSPECTIVE

We began this unit by studying Harold Lasswell's model, which attempts to answer who says what to whom, through what channel and with what effect. This model and most other models discussed above fall within the dominant paradigm, which is concerned with the technical efficiency of communication in transmitting or transporting information from the source to the destination. Thus, the two ends of this process (the source and the destination) determine that linearity will be embedded in how we approach communication. This is known as the transmission perspective of the communication models.

According to Dennis McQuail, the message is determined by the source in the transmission-driven models. One of the problems with the transmission perspective is that it looks at communication in an instrumental way to bind it in a cause-and-effect format. Several of the models discussed come under the rubric of transmission perspective, which is geared towards a one-dimensional message for

from the sender to the receiver.

James Carey, a communication scholar, introduced the **Ritual or Expressive model** of communication that depends on shared meanings and culture. The purpose of communication, as conceptualised in the ritual perspective, is not to bring out an 'effect' or to persuade someone but to bring out the pleasures of a shared culture. Communication is not seen as a practical function but as a symbolic process whereby 'reality is produced, maintained, repaired and transformed.' The purpose of communication is not for control but for the representation of shared beliefs. In the ritual model, importance is given to the performative quality of communication rather than its efficiency. Therefore, meanings may be ambiguous and latent, drawing from a timeless shared culture everyone knows.

In this context, it is interesting to see how advertisements ultimately use the ritual communication model to persuade viewers to buy their products. For example, a familiar image in a commercial for cooking oil is a mother frying *pooris* for her children. This image draws upon the idea of purity and authenticity through the notion of 'mother's love', thus reinforcing the idea of women as nurturers. So the commercial is not just about selling cooking oil but equally about creating familiar symbolic associations that are part of a shared culture.

Transmission models usually suspect the audience to be passive, and the meanings exist only waiting to be decoded correctly. It severely underestimates the dynamic act of interpretation. It also shifts the power fulcrum in favour of the sender. Alternative models are described as constructivist models. They acknowledge that all parties involved can generate and deconstruct meanings rather than rely on senders and receivers. However, scholars in this field reject producing scaled diagrams or structuring the communication process. Instead, they opine that attaching meaning to a set of symbols is situated in the socio-cultural and political context.

2.11 LET US SUM UP

This unit aims to help us better understand the communication process with the help of models several scholars have devised. Using models as a tool, we can map the communication process in a graphic form; this helps us better understand the flow of communication. Each model gives importance to different elements that are essential for communication. We notice that as we go along, the models become more and more complex, leading us to ask different kinds of questions. This leads us towards more research and further need for models.

2.12 KEYWORDS

Mathematical model: Linear or telephone model of communication. Also known as the engineering model.

Encoder: Sender of a message.

Decoder: Receiver of a message.

Semantics: Meanings attached to words.

Fields of experience: Periphery of total human experience.

Gatekeeping: Filtering mechanism of messages.

Ritual model: Focusses on shared meanings and culture.

Agenda setting: The theory that the media provide topics of discussion and importance for consumers.

Codebook: A menu or list of responses used in coding open-ended questions.

Construct: A combination of concepts that are created to describe a specific situation (for example, “authoritarianism”).

Degrees of freedom: An intentional and predetermined reduction in sample size to provide a conservative data adjustment to compensate for research error.

Homogeneity: Equality of control and experimental groups before an experiment; also called point of prior equivalency.

Longitudinal Study: The collection of data at different points in time.

Scientific Method: A systematic, controlled, empirical, and critical investigation of hypothetical propositions about the presumed relationships among natural phenomena.

Open-ended Question: A question to which respondents are asked to generate an answer or answers with no prompting from the item itself (for example, “What is your favourite type of television program?”).

Proposition: A statement of the form “if *A*, then *B*” that links two or more concepts.

Sample: A subgroup or subset of a population or universe.

Secondary Analysis: The use of data collected by a previous researcher or another research organisation; also called data re-analysis.

2.13 FURTHER READINGS

Books:

1. Griffin, E. (2018). *A First Look at Communication Theory*. McGraw-Hill Education.
2. Littlejohn, S. W., & Foss, K. A. (2011). *Theories of Human Communication*. Waveland Press.
3. West, R., & Turner, L. H. (2017). *Introducing Communication Theory: Analysis and Application*. McGraw-Hill Education.

Journal Articles

4. Shannon, C. E., & Weaver, W. (1949). The Mathematical Theory of Communication. *The Bell System Technical Journal*, 27(3), 379-423.
5. Berlo, D. K. (1960). *The Process of Communication: An Introduction to Theory and Practice*. Holt, Rinehart and Winston.
6. Lasswell, H. D. (1948). The Structure and Function of Communication in Society. In L. Bryson (Ed.), *The Communication of Ideas* (pp. 37-51). Harper.

Online Articles:

7. McQuail, D. (2010). *Mass Communication Theory*. Sage Publications.

8. Craig, R. T. (1999). Communication theory as a field. *Communication Theory*, 9(2), 119-161.
9. Osgood, C. E., Suci, G. J., & Tannenbaum, P. H. (1957). *The Measurement of Meaning*. University of Illinois Press.

2.14 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Semantic noise occurs when there is a difference in understanding the meaning of the communicated message between the encoder and decoder (sender and receiver).
2. The sender will be able to understand the effectiveness of his message with the help of feedback, which would lead to better communication. The feedback element makes Schramm's model reciprocal and highly interactive.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Gatekeeping not only filters the initial message sent across but can also add opinions and views of the person doing the gatekeeping to the message being sent forward.
2. The six functions are emotive, referential, poetic, phatic, multilingual and conative.

THE PEOPLE'S
UNIVERSITY

UNIT 3 EMERGENCE OF DIGITAL MEDIA

Structure

- 3.0 Introduction
- 3.1 Learning Outcomes
- 3.2 Defining Digital Media
 - 3.2.1 Understanding Digital, Online and New Media
- 3.3 Characteristics of Digital Media
 - 3.3.1 Interactivity
 - 3.3.2 Convergence
 - 3.3.3 Immediacy
 - 3.3.4 Archiving
 - 3.3.5 Linkages
- 3.4 Digital Media in India
 - 3.4.1 Digital Landscape
 - 3.4.2 Digital Media: Historical Perspective
- 3.5 Digital Media and Journalism: Emerging Trends
 - 3.5.1 Data-Driven Journalism
 - 3.5.2 Digital Stories
 - 3.5.3 Mapping in Journalism
- 3.6 Challenges
 - 3.6.1 Fake Information
 - 3.6.2 Online Abuse Threats and Trolling
- 3.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 3.8 Further Readings
- 3.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

3.0 INTRODUCTION

From reading newspapers to watching television, from listening to the radio and watching films, every media consumption experience has been affected by the emergence of Digital media. Newspapers are being read on laptops, tablets and smartphones. Even while reading the print version, there is always a temptation to go online to watch a video using a certain app. Online mediums the world over are giving tough competition to Print and TV. Many people consume media messages not from established television channels but by subscribing to YouTubers. Radio sets are often unused in households as people are tuned into their favourite channels through smartphones. The medium has not only affected the consumption pattern but also the way media messages are produced. New technologies have impacted every function in a media house. Old ways of working on certain products have been replaced by new ways of packaging information, influenced by new technologies.

In this unit, we shall discuss the emergence of digital media, the digital media landscape, opportunities and challenges that come with digital media and its impact on traditional media. Different terms are used interchangeably for Digital Media, like online media, new media, ICT, etc. All these terms will be discussed for your conceptual understanding.

3.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you will be able to:

- describe what digital media is and how it has impacted the media landscape;
- articulate the effect of digital media on legacy media and how legacy media has adapted to recent technological advancements;
- analyse the challenges posed by digital media; and
- explore and use digital tools for constructing media messages.

3.2 DEFINING DIGITAL MEDIA

Every industry is relooking and reinventing various processes like production, resource management, and marketing and is aligning them to the rules of the digital world. The Media Industry, too, has undergone a sea change through the digital transformation process. Every function of a media organisation has been affected by new technologies in recent years. While some media houses were prompt and active in embracing these changes, others lagged. Laggards, though, could not resist the change for long and had to hop onto the digital wagon to survive in the industry. Slowly, they, too, embraced technology's meaningful role in the digital world.

3.2.1 Understanding Digital, Online and New Media

In the context of Media, several terms are used interchangeably, like New Media, Information and Communication Technologies, Digital Media, Online media, Multimedia, Convergence media, etc. There are some overlaps, but the meaning varies with the context. Let us explore the meaning of these terms:

- **Information and Communication Technologies:** According to the World Bank, ICT consists of hardware, software, networks, and media for the collection, storage, processing, transmission, and presentation of information (voice, data, text, images)
- **Digital Media:** The digital process breaks down all information(data, text graphics, audio, pictures or video into a sequence of numbers (digits), transports it by wire, cable or broadcast frequency to a destination and then re-assembles it back into its original form. Digital media refers to audio, video, and photo content that has been encoded (digitally compressed). Encoding content involves converting audio and video input into a digital media file like a Windows Media file. After digital media is encoded, it can be easily manipulated, distributed, and rendered (played) by computers and is easily transmitted over computer

networks. Examples of digital media types include Windows Media Audio (WMA), Windows Media Video (WMV), MP3, JPEG, and AVI.

- **New Media:** New Media refers to those digital Media that are interactive, incorporate two-way communication and involve some form of computing as opposed to 'old media' such as telephone, radio and TV, according to Robert Logan (2010).
- **Online Media:** This generic term is often used loosely to describe digital information access, retrieval or dissemination. This means accessing information on the Internet via a modem or telephone line.
- **Multimedia:** This means using more than one media technique (text, audio, still images, moving images) to tell a story. A multimedia news story is any piece that uses two or more media to tell it.

The abovementioned terms are deeply linked and thus are difficult to distinguish. The significance of limiting this definition is largely contextual. While Information and Communication Technology encompasses everything from hardware to software and includes information dissemination, the focus is on what makes any information digital in the Digital Media definition. In New Media, stress is on how digital media is used with interaction and two-way communication as its important feature. Multimedia combines two or more media techniques, which is easily possible only when the information is available in digital format. While there is an overlapping basis, each of these terms has some distinct feature. For this chapter, the term Digital Media will include online platforms, social media, new digital tools, and new ways of packaging and disseminating information, all in the media industry context.

3.3 CHARACTERISTICS OF DIGITAL MEDIA

There has been a massive growth in the popularity of the digital media world over the last decade. In fact, digital media is seen as a threat to legacy media. Wherever there is a decline in newspapers' readership, Digital has been quoted as one of the major reasons. Whether digital is responsible for the decline in the growth of legacy media will be explored in the sub-sections later in this unit. In this section, the focus will be on the characteristics that made digital media a popular platform.

3.3.1 Interactivity

The most important characteristic distinguishing Digital Media from traditional media is 'interactivity'. It allows people to rate, share, like and comment on any message. There is a shift from the limited interactivity that traditional media offered earlier in the form of letters to the editor or feedback programmes on TV and radio to the unlimited interactivity that digital media offers. This interactivity not only allows people to respond or react to the messages constructed by the media houses but also turns the consumer into a producer, wherein people are not just consuming media messages but also constructing media messages. This feature has turned passive consumers into active producers. Most news portals nowadays offer users opportunities to interact with the content (in the case of interactive

stories), interact with the content producers, and provide space for user-generated content.

The report for CNN is an example of how mainstream media encourages its audience to interact with the platform. Here, the interaction is not just by writing comments or rating stories done by CNN. Still, iReport for CNN" is an interactive, international monthly half-hour TV program showcasing the most newsworthy and informative iReport contributions and citizen journalism reports on the Internet. Besides sending it to the platform, citizens can post it on Facebook, Instagram or Twitter with the hashtag #CNNiReport. Check the following website to know more:

<http://edition.cnn.com/CNN/Programs/ireport/>

Activity – 1

There are many examples of citizen journalism. Try to find case studies where mainstream media welcomed contributions from citizen journalists.

3.3.2 Convergence

Digital Media makes the merging of various mass communication formats like print, television and radio. On the Internet, every medium resides next to another. You can listen to an audio interview, watch the event, and read the story simultaneously. Journalists are using one medium to tell one aspect of the story and another medium to tell another aspect. For example, a story on a satellite launch in India might use an explainer video to explain demonetisation, photographs to describe how it is being implemented, text to analyse the initiative and audio for interviews with the experts. All these elements could be combined to tell a story about launching a satellite. This is also called *multimedia journalism*. In this case, each media element is an important part of the story. Multimedia reporting is usually confused with parallel reporting. Two or three journalists cover a story for print, video or audio in parallel reporting. In such cases, these stories are independent as they are separate stories told by different journalists. Even if it is uploaded on the website, the only thing they have in common is the subject; otherwise, stories differ. In multimedia journalism, various media elements are weaved into the story according to the story's requirements. There are a number of digital tools which can help journalists to write multimedia stories. Some examples of multimedia stories can be seen at the following link: <https://infogr.am/examples>.

3.3.3 Immediacy

Another important characteristic of Digital Media is immediacy. On radio and television, only one thing can be shown at one time, and to show another, the previous one has to be interrupted; on websites, one can have multiple stories, and the same can be updated as the developments on those events occur. A single story can post a number of updates on one story. By introducing live broadcasts, social networking sites have changed the game altogether. Traditional Media houses, as well as locals, can broadcast any event live. The broadcast feature offers many opportunities with just a

Smartphone in hand and no other infrastructure. But at the same time, the use of this feature has drawn a lot of criticism.

Live broadcasts are a new trend, and to add to this is the latest feature of 360 videos by the Live broadcast app like Periscope. So it is not just a live shot, but with 360 videos on Periscope, one can experience moments with the broadcaster and look around — it's one step closer to being there.

Activity – 2

Explore Facebook Live to broadcast local events in your area.

3.3.4 Archiving

Another characteristic differentiating digital from legacy media is its inherent capacity to archive news stories, videos, audio and infographics. The shelf life of news, which used to be very limited, has increased tremendously with all sorts of content lying on different shelves of the website. One can visit that content anytime. The tags and keywords act as keys to those shelves. For example, an article on global trade can be accessed by typing a search query in the search box. If the article is given a tag like trade, Indian economy, etc., retrieving it from the repository of millions of articles will be easy. So it is important to have a well-archived website, but at the same, it should be well-searchable. Archiving can also help writers provide important context to what they are presently writing and can be an excellent resource for research. For readers, it provides an opportunity for non-linear consumption of content. They can create their own stories by reading different pieces written by different writers at different times.

3.3.5 Linkages

Archiving and information available on the web make linkages possible. It is easy to link the article to something written earlier on the same topic or with an article on the same subject written by a different writer. Linkages provide depth to the story. In Digital, for any story, the amount of space is limited, as is the case in print, TV and radio, where there is limited space and time. In legacy media, the challenge is to tell the entire story in the limited time and space allocated to it, and digital media overcomes this challenge by providing links to other relevant material. It could be an article on the same website or some report lying outside it. While linkages broaden the story's scope, and multiple angles can be explored simultaneously, they pose the challenge of losing a reader to another website or content. It becomes very difficult to bring readers back to the site once they are navigated out of the website to look for some other content. Therefore, it is important to use linkages strategically in any story.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Once digital media is encoded, it can be easily....., and by computers, and is easily transmitted over computer networks.

2. CNN is an example of how mainstream media encourages its audience to interact with the platform.
3. Write four characteristics of Digital media.

4. With Digital Media, there is a shift from limited interactivity to unlimited interactivity. Discuss.

3.4 DIGITAL MEDIA IN INDIA

3.4.1 Digital Landscape

India is going through a digital revolution. The amount of growth India has seen in internet penetration is unprecedented. India has become the second largest country in the world regarding Internet users, with 692 million (as of 2023) people connected to the Internet after China. The penetration is 34.8 %, according to <http://www.internetlivestats.com> (**Internet Live Stats** is part of the *Real-Time Statistics Project, which provides live internet data*). The government's Digital India Programme (Digital India programme has been launched by the Department of Electronics and Information Technology, Ministry of Communications and Information Technology, Government of India) has given a fillip to digital media in India. The Digital India campaign is centred around three visions:

- digital infrastructure is a core utility for every citizen governance and services on demand
- digital empowerment of citizens

All the digital initiatives to fulfil the abovementioned visions will significantly strengthen digital media in India. While it has already contributed to increasing the number of internet users in India, implementing Digital infrastructure as a core utility to every citizen will also increase internet penetration, which is low compared to other countries. India has also seen tremendous growth in mobile use for data and voice. Though it took subscribers, India has become one of the largest mobile markets in the world. This trend encouraged people in the media industry to take Media Mobile Apps seriously. Several media houses have created apps to connect with those 600 million subscribers. Also, because of the popularity of platforms like WhatsApp and Facebook, there is a need to repurpose content for those consuming media messages.

Media industry researchers have shown that media content creation, access and consumption have gone through enormous changes in the second decade of the 21st century, globally as well as in India, and shifts will be more dramatic over the next five years. Three main factors responsible for this trend are:

- Technology and internet access, especially fast mobile data and broadband
- Gadgets, especially smartphones and streaming media devices
- The app ecosystem

The growth in digital advertising has been the maximum over the last few years compared to other media segments. This massive growth is the increase in the internet user base, including mobile internet users.

3.4.2 Digital Media: Historical Perspective

Digital Media and Print Media

In India, The Hindu was the first newspaper to start its website in 1995. After that, most newspapers built their own websites to connect with those who had Internet access. In 2007, *Malayala Manorama* became the first regional newspaper to establish its presence in digital media by launching a mobile app. Newspapers like The Times of India, The Hindustan Times, The Hindu and The Indian Express joined Twitter in 2009-2010. In 2012, TOI forayed into augmented reality by launching its Alive App. The app allows users to scan any picture or graphic and then take them to the relevant multimedia content. In 2013, mobile media apps became very popular. One app that emerged as a leader was 'Inshorts'. The app was an instant success based on the premise that people would like to consume messages quickly. Hence, the news is constructed to deliver the entire story in a few words.

To make their content easily accessible through search engines, many media outlets forayed into Search Engine Optimisation and Digital marketing. Social media marketing became as important as the content. Media houses train their staff or hire digital marketing agencies to be on top of the Search Engine Result page list and get more clicks and traffic.

A lot of experiments were being done in the ways news was told. A number of digital tools were explored that allowed the development of stories in different ways. This was the year of *immersive storytelling*. Malayala Manorama online started offering 360-degree videos.

Immersive storytelling aims to give the consumers a feeling of really being there' by using 3D gaming, 360-degree videos, and virtual and augmented reality technologies. The delivery of news and storytelling is made more hard-hitting and entertaining using advanced technologies.

Digital Media & TV

Online videos have exploded with the increase in internet connectivity and the availability of cheap smartphones. Anyone who had access to technology and internet-enabled phones also had the opportunity to create and

disseminate videos. One could also do something unheard of until a few years back; one could create one's own channel. Depending on the interest, YouTube is full of channels on DIYs, politics, news, entertainment, travel, food etc. The reach of many of these channels is much more than that of a traditional TV channel. The last few years have witnessed massive growth in the number of videos created and uploaded. In addition to internet connectivity and cheap smartphones, this was made possible by new digital tools that allow creating and editing videos on the go.

Most social networking websites like Facebook, Snapchat, and Twitter integrated these tools so that anyone could create and disseminate these videos for the forty-two per cent of the world population connected to the Internet. Some of the emerging trends we are witnessing nowadays are immersive storytelling (360-degree videos), video selfies, etc. The Quint, an online news platform, roped in Barkha Dutt, a senior journalist, during the 2017 state elections (UP) for new media journalism. She used selfie videos and Facebook Live extensively to cover UP elections.

Also, The New York Times announced its launch on the Snap Chat Discover forum in 2017. The idea was to reach 41 % of all 18-34-year-olds in the US using Snapchat. An average US TV network reaches 6% of the same demographic.

The Quint and The New York Times examples show how new technology shapes media messages' construction. TV no longer has a monopoly over videos; even online newspapers host videos on their portal.

Digital Media and Radio

Considering the increase in internet penetration and growth of smartphone segments in India, traditional broadcast radio channels have taken their stations online, and some companies run internet-based radio services.

Radio has remained a strong partner in the media and marketing mix.

Radio broadcasters are adapting well to how digital channels are changing the industry, turning mobile phones and the Internet into a way to extend their brands, protect their listener share, and reach new audiences. Radio stations these days have also created engaging websites and apps where audiences can listen to podcasts, stream radio broadcasts and experience visual, video, text or interactive content.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Which department has been entrusted with launching and implementing the Digital India programme?

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2. Three visions of the Digital India programme are:

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3. In 2012, TOI forayed into augmented reality by launching.

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4. 4 is an app that delivers news content in limited words.

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3.5 DIGITAL MEDIA AND JOURNALISM: EMERGING TRENDS

3.5.1 Data-Driven Journalism

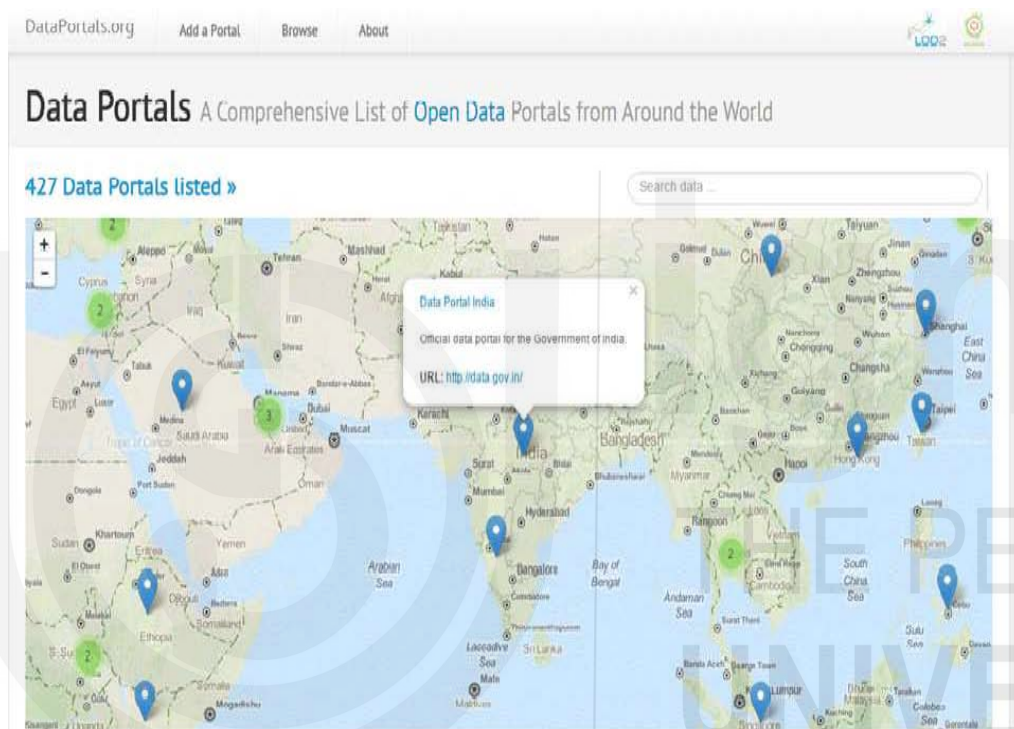
Data Journalism, big data, and data analytics are buzzwords nowadays. Data is being used by media houses to tell stories. The open data movement has made it easier for communicators and journalists to access and use data. Many countries are releasing their data as open data so that the public can use it for various purposes. In India, the www.data.gov.in platform hosts data from all the Ministries and departments.



The data.gov.in results from the National Data Sharing and Accessibility Policy (NDSAP), which the Government of India notified in March 2012 to

promote a culture of data sharing and data utility for meeting larger socio-economic goals. Adhering to the norms laid out by this policy, the National Informatics Centre (NIC) has set up Open Government Data (OGD) Platform India – (<http://data.gov.in>), which is a state-of-the-art dynamic data-sharing platform espousing the principle of Open Government Data. The portal has many rich features to support this policy, such as:

'Search & Discovery' mechanism for instant access to various datasets of great importance Community engagements around published datasets for innovative applications On open data with an ability to provide customised citizen services. Tools/ Apps/Visualisation developed by using this platform have played a pivotal role in increasing transparency and citizens' participation in the governance process.



Data Portals.org is the most comprehensive list of open data portals worldwide.

It is curated by a group of leading open data experts from around the world - including representatives from local, regional and national governments, international organisations such as the World Bank, and numerous NGOs. The data on these platforms are freely available for the researchers to work on.

According to David Anderton, a freelance journalist, Data journalism is bridging the gap between statisticians and wordsmiths.

Data journalism is about using sheer scale and range of digital information to tell compelling stories. Data journalism focuses not on what happened but on what a particular development means.

There are several digital tools which are available to work on data-based stories. Some of the tools are as follows:

1. Google fusion table

2. Lucid chart
3. Silk
4. Infogram
5. Picktochart
6. Tableaux
7. Carto

Activity - 3

Explore the following website to see the amount and range of data available:
www.data.gov.in

3.5.2 Digital stories

Digital stories are a new way of storytelling. This means telling stories by using computer-based tools. They are also known as digital documentaries, computer-based narratives, digital essays, electronic memoirs and interactive storytelling. *They all revolve around the idea of combining the art of telling stories with a variety of multimedia, including graphics, audio, video, and Web publishing.*

The duration of digital stories is shorter, i.e. from 2 to 5 minutes. Some of the tools which are used to tell digital stories are:

1. Powtoon
2. Moovly
3. We video

Activity - 4

Following is the link to the digital story on the Panama leaks. Watch this to understand the concept which is explained with Piggy Banks. Find out more digital stories on the web and attempt to make one yourself on a subject of your choice.

3.5.3 Mapping in Journalism

'Where' is the important element of the 5Ws and one H in journalism. It describes where the event took place and can tell a great deal about the story. Geography, culture, politics and economics have to do much with any event occurring at a particular place. So if it is news about the Nepal earthquake, the geographical features of that place become important, and if it is news related to the Arab Spring, the political environment of those countries in the Middle East becomes important. While a few years back, the name of the place in the story was enough, or one or two shots of the location were adequate. Today, we are at a time when digitally savvy readers prefer to have immersive experiences. How about feeling the place, exploring more than one shot offers, navigating from one place to another or visiting different locations to find more information? It would be interesting and enriching to be a part of the scene and experience the fun, excitement, horror, and pain accompanied by the story.

With live broadcasts and geo-tagging, much information is generated from

various locations. The information generated from various sites can be an excellent resource for journalists. Putting this information together and converting it into a story can be challenging.

Mapping can be a powerful storytelling tool which journalists can use to take their audience on a journey following a narrative storyline or to illustrate and make sense of fast-moving breaking news events (Catalina Albeanu 2014).

Mapping places and live broadcasts are emerging trends, and to add to this is the latest feature of 360-degree video by the Live broadcast app like Periscope. So it is not just a live shot, but with 360-degree video on Periscope, one can experience moments with the broadcaster and look around — it's one step closer to being there.

The new technologies have made both the generation and storage of data possible. There is a lot of data based on locations. According to Gustavo Faleiros, data journalist and media trainer, most data sets contain location-related information that makes them good candidates for mapping. “Maps are also a great tool for allowing user interaction,” said, “and just a great way to tell stories.”

There are hundreds of tools available to create maps. Some are free, some paid, and some are available on the Freemium model. The learning curve for these tools is also varied. Some tools can be learned easily, and some have a steep learning curve. To get started, Google Maps is the easiest option. One can start by mapping schools, colleges or the places to visit or places visited, to begin with. Google My Maps can be accessed by searching in the search engine or Go <https://www.google.com/maps/d/>

How to Create Your Map

- Step 1 Visit Google Maps and click on the menu
- Step 2 In the Menu, click your places
- Step 3 Create maps. Other tools for mapping are:
 - 1) Google fusion table
 - 2) Story map
 - 3) Carto
 - 4) Infogram

Activity - 5

Create your Map by using Google My Maps.

3.6 CHALLENGES

3.6.1 Fake Information

While digital media has made the work of communicators easier by providing cheap platforms and easy-to-use digital tools, it also poses many challenges for the producers and consumers of media messages. Digital Media has undoubtedly democratised the media landscape by allowing others to create

and disseminate. Anyone can be a producer, director, writer or distributor, but this also poses a lot of challenges. There is a lot of information available on the web that is inaccurate. Hence, a new term, "Post Truth", was coined, which means "circumstances in which objective facts are less influential in shaping public opinion than appeals to emotion and personal belief."

During the US presidential election, we have seen a barrage of fake news like the Pope's support for Donald Trump and Hillary's link with ISIS. Hundreds of fake websites were created in Macedonia to spread such false information. In India, too, we witness the continuous flow of such messages on WhatsApp, Twitter and Facebook. A lot of initiatives are being taken to curb this. Facebook has added "It's a fake News story" options for the users to report any fake story. Facebook will also flag fake news stories with the help of users and third-party fact-checkers. Many third-party fact-checking organisations have sprung up in the last few years to curb the flow of false information. Organisations like the International Fact-Checking Network lead the movement. As part of this network, more than 100 websites conduct fact checks. In India, two organisations conduct fact checks: fact check-in and check4spam.com. Though there is a need for such initiatives, this should be supported by a digital literacy campaign.

3.6.2 Online Abuse, Threats and Trolling

The Internet has made lives easier for those who want to use it for constructive purposes and those who want to use it in destructive and disruptive ways. This practice of using the Internet in destructive ways in a social setting with no apparent instrumental purpose is termed Internet Trolling. The concept has emerged recently, and research is being done on Internet Trolling. The purpose and intent of trolls, their psychology and their process of creating chaos online is an important area of study, considering the drastic increase in the number of such cases worldwide. A closer look at the trolls and their comments shows a pattern. From a person seeking attention by being disruptive to one enjoying hurting others and displaying sadism to the one taking advantage of being anonymous online, internet trolls can be categorised in a number of ways.

Who are *Internet trolls*?

Internet Trolls are individuals on the web who connect to create chaos. According to researcher Dr. Claire Hardaker, a troll is "a computer user who constructs the identity of sincerely wishing to be part of the group in question ... but whose real intention is to cause disruption and/or trigger conflict for the purposes of one's own amusement."

Dr. Claire categorised trolls in the following manners according to their intent and the people or issues they target.

1. RIP trolls who spend their time causing misery on memorial sites
2. Fame trolls who focus all their energies on provoking celebrities;
3. Care trolls, who purport to see abuse in every post about children or animals

4. Political trolls who seek to bully MPs out of office, and many others besides.

Helen Lewis (2014), in her article "Who are the trolls", published in New Statesman, added two more categories to this:

1. Subcultural trolls - or "true" trolls - are the ones who trawl forums full of earnest people and derail their conversations with silly questions, or hackers
2. Professional trolls" or "columnists" are writers and public figures whose media careers are built on their willingness to "say the unsayable" or, rather, say something which will attract huge volumes of attention (albeit negative) and hits.

Reasons for Internet Trolling

US Researcher Alice Marwick gives the following explanation for Internet Trolling: "There's the disturbing possibility that people are creating online environments purely to express the type of racist, homophobic, or sexist speech that is no longer acceptable in public society, at work, or even at home." Anonymity, hence, is the biggest reason for Internet Trolling. This anonymity leads to online disinhibition, which is one of the characteristics of Internet Trolling. According to Psychologist John Suller (2004), some people self-disclose or act out more frequently or intensely when they are online. He explored six factors that interact with each other in creating this online disinhibition effect: dissociative anonymity, invisibility, synchronicity, solipsistic introjection, dissociative imagination, and minimisation of authority. Personality variables also will influence the extent of this disinhibition. All the above factors described by Suller trigger internet Trolling.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What is the main objective of open data movement?

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2. is the most comprehensive list of open data portals in the world.

3. Name three digital tools that can help you to work on data-based stories.

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4. Name three digital tools that can help you to create Maps.

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5. What do you understand by "Post truth."

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3.7 LET US SUM UP

Digital Media in India is growing at a very fast pace. This trend will continue considering the various initiatives under digital India that will strengthen the digital infrastructure. The Indian Media Industry has embraced digital, and all the platforms, including print, magazines, TV and radio, are adapting to remain relevant in the digital era. Digital Media offers a lot of opportunities, like new ways of storytelling, marketing and research. Still, at the same time, it is being criticised for creating a lot of chaos by spreading false information, and issues like trolling have caught many's attention in recent years. The medium offers many features; it is up to the people how these features can be exploited constructively. The vision of Digital India puts it very succinctly that with Digital infrastructure for every citizen and government service on demand, there is also a great need for digital empowerment of citizens if India has to become a digitally empowered society and knowledge economy.

3.8 FURTHER READINGS

1. Eric Schmidt & Jared Cohen (2013). *The New Digital Age: Reshaping the Future of People, Nations, and Business*. John Murray.
2. Hardaker, C. (2010). "Trolling in asynchronous computer-mediated communication: From user discussions to academic definitions." *Journal of Politeness Research. Language, Behaviour, Culture*.
3. Helen Lewis (2014). "Who are the trolls." *New Statesman*. Retrieved from <http://www.newstatesman.com/helen-lewis/2013/07/who-are-trolls>
4. Jessica Valenti. "How the web became a sexists' paradise." *The Guardian*. Retrieved from <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2007/apr/06/gender.blogging>
5. John Suller. "The Psychology of Cyber Space." Retrieved from <http://truecenterpublishing.com/psycyber/disinhibit.html>.
6. John Vince, & Rae Earnshaw (1999). *Digital Convergence: The Information Revolution*. Springer.
7. Lotz, A. D. (2009). "What is US television now?" In E. Katz & P. Scannell (Eds.), *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and*

8. Michael M.A. Mirabito, & Barbara L. Morgenstern (2004). The New Communication Technologies: Applications, Policy, and Impact. Focal Press.

3.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Once digital media is encoded, it can be easily **manipulated**, **distributed**, and **rendered** (played) by computers and is easily transmitted over computer networks
2. **iReport** for CNN is an example of how mainstream media encourages its audience to interact with the platform
3. Interactivity, Immediacy, Linkages, Convergence
4. This means traditional media offered limited interactivity earlier in the form of letters to the editor or feedback programmes on TV and radio. In contrast, digital media provides an opportunity for unlimited interactivity. This interactivity not only allows people to respond or react to the messages constructed by the media houses but also turns the consumer into a producer, wherein people are not just consuming media messages but also constructing media messages. This feature has turned passive consumers into active producers.

Check Your Progress 2

1. The Digital India Programme has been launched by the Department of Electronics and Information Technology, Ministry of Communications and Information Technology, Government of India)
2. Digital Infrastructure as a core utility for every citizen Governance and services on demand Digital empowerment of citizens
3. Alive App
4. Inshorts

Check Your Progress 3

1. To promote a culture of data sharing and data utility for larger socio-economic goal
2. DataPortals.org is the most comprehensive list of open data portals in the world.
3. Infogram, Google fusion table, Carto
4. Google My Maps, Storymaps, Google Fusion table
5. Circumstances in which objective facts are less influential in shaping public opinion than appeals to emotion and personal belief.”

UNIT 4 JOURNALISM, DIGITAL MEDIA AND SOCIETY

Structure

- 4.0 Introduction
- 4.1 Learning Outcomes
- 4.2 Understanding Journalism
 - 4.2.1 Concept and Definitions
 - 4.2.2 Evolution and Growth
 - 4.2.3 Changing Forms of Journalism
 - 4.2.4 Emerging Challenges
- 4.3 Digital Media and Journalism
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 - 4.3.4 Case Studies of Digital Journalism
- 4.4 Journalism and Society
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- 4.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

4.0 INTRODUCTION

The modern era has witnessed a profound transformation in how news and information are disseminated, shared, and consumed. Digital media's advent has revolutionised journalism's landscape, significantly impacting society at large. By blending traditional reporting with the power of technology, journalists now have unprecedented avenues to reach and connect with their audiences.

At its core, journalism is a vital pillar of democratic societies, acting as a watchdog, holding power accountable, and informing the public. However, with the rise of digital media, the traditional boundaries of journalism have expanded, giving rise to new challenges and opportunities, blurring the line between professional journalism and citizen reporting.

This paradigm shift has implications not only for the media industry but also for society as a whole.

Thus, this unit will delve into the multifaceted interactions between journalism, digital media, and society. We will examine the impact of social media platforms on news consumption patterns, the challenges journalists face in navigating the digital landscape, and the ethical considerations that arise in this new media ecosystem.

4.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you will be able to:

- understand the impact of digital media on journalism and society;
- recognise the role of journalism as a pillar of democratic institutions;
- explore the challenges and opportunities presented by digital media in journalism;
- develop critical thinking skills to evaluate the reliability and credibility of news sources in the digital age; and
- acquire knowledge about the interplay between journalism, digital media, and society in an ever-evolving media landscape.

4.2 UNDERSTANDING JOURNALISM

From investigative reporting to storytelling, journalism plays a pivotal role in our society by uncovering truths, shaping public opinion, and holding those in power accountable. Get ready to explore journalism's principles, practices, and impact as we unravel its significance in our world today.

4.2.1 Concept and Definitions

Some prominent definitions of Journalism are given below:

"Journalism can never be silent: that is its greatest virtue and its greatest fault." - Henry Anatole Grunwald

"Journalism is printing what someone else does not want printed. Everything else is public relations." - George Orwell

"Journalism is the first draft of history. It is the medium through which news, ideas, and opinions are communicated to the masses. It plays a crucial role in fostering democracy and facilitating public discourse."- M. Chalapathi Rao

"Journalism is about telling stories that matter. It is the pursuit of truth, driven by a commitment to social justice. Journalists are responsible for highlighting the marginalised, questioning authority, and amplifying diverse perspectives."-P. Sainath

"News is what somebody does not want you to print. All the rest is advertising." - William Randolph Hearst

Journalism is the art and practice of gathering, verifying, and presenting news and information to the public. It involves investigating stories, conducting interviews, and reporting on relevant and significant societal events.

4.2.2 Evolution and Growth

Journalism in India has a rich and extensive history that can be traced back to the colonial era. The first newspaper, The Bengal Gazette, was established in 1780 by James Augustus Hickey. However, it faced challenges and was shut down in 1782 due to its outspoken criticism of the British administration. The British introduced independent press or participatory journalism during the colonial period in India. However, they also imposed restrictions on the Indian media to control the spread of nationalistic sentiments. One significant measure was the Press Act of 1910, which allowed the local government to demand a security fee for any content deemed offensive towards the government. This act resulted in the prosecution of nearly 1,000 newspapers. In response to such censorship, the All-India Newspapers Editors' Conference was established as a defender of press rights in the country.

Historical, technological, and societal factors have driven the evolution and growth of journalism in India. The profession has expanded its reach, embracing new mediums and empowering citizens to engage actively with news and information. Journalism continues to evolve, adapt, and play a crucial role in shaping public discourse and promoting an informed society.

4.2.3 Changing Forms of Journalism

Journalism in India has witnessed significant transformations in recent years, driven by evolving technology, changing media consumption patterns, and societal shifts.

Digital Journalism: With the advent of the Internet, digital journalism has gained prominence, offering new ways to gather, produce, and consume news. Online news portals, blogs, and social media platforms have become popular sources of information.

Data Journalism: Data journalism involves analysing and visualising complex data sets to uncover meaningful stories. It enhances transparency, facilitates in-depth reporting, and empowers audiences with data-driven insights.

Example: Mongabay-India published a series of articles that used data to show the impact of climate change on India.

Citizen Journalism: Citizen journalism enables ordinary individuals to participate in news production. With the proliferation of smartphones and social media, people can capture and share news events in real-time.

Multimedia Journalism: Multimedia journalism combines various formats, such as text, images, audio, and video, to present news stories in a more engaging and immersive manner. It caters to diverse audience preferences.

Mobile Journalism: Mobile journalism, or MoJo, involves using smartphones and mobile devices to gather, edit, and publish news content. It

enables journalists to report from anywhere, enhancing speed and flexibility.

Investigative Journalism: Investigative journalism is vital in exposing corruption, injustice, and societal issues. It involves in-depth research, interviews, and critical analysis to uncover hidden truths and hold power accountable.

4.2.4 Emerging Challenges

Journalism in India faces emerging challenges that significantly hinder its practice and integrity.

Fake News and Misinformation: The proliferation of digital platforms has given rise to the rapid spread of fake news and misinformation. False narratives, manipulated images, and misleading information can quickly circulate, undermining the credibility of journalism.

Commercial Pressures and Sensationalism: Media commercialisation has led to pressures for higher ratings and increased revenue, often resulting in sensationalised news coverage.

Shrinking Space for Investigative Journalism: The shrinking financial resources and limited support for investigative journalism restrict the ability to pursue in-depth reporting.

Social Media and Echo Chambers: The echo chamber effect on social media platforms contributes to the polarisation of public discourse. Users tend to follow like-minded individuals and consume content aligning with their beliefs, reinforcing biases and narrowing perspectives.

Activity - 1

Find out any five fake news stories in your area and check whether they emanate from social media.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

True or False:

1. Digital journalism involves analysing and visualising complex data sets to uncover meaningful stories. (True/False)
2. False narratives, manipulated images, and misleading information are examples of Fake News. (True/False)
3. The Echo Chamber effect is related to social media. (True/False)

4.3 DIGITAL MEDIA AND JOURNALISM

Digital media has revolutionised journalism, impacting how news is created, distributed, and consumed. In the past, journalists relied on traditional methods like writing, photography, and video production, submitting their work to news organisations for editing and publication. However, with the

rise of digital media, journalists now have various tools and platforms.

The advent of digital media has led to a more decentralised and participatory form of journalism. With a smartphone and internet connection, anyone can engage in journalism, contributing to a diverse and dynamic news landscape. Social media platforms, such as Facebook and Twitter, have become valuable sources for news discovery, enabling journalists to find stories and reach wider audiences.

Moreover, digital media has transformed news consumption patterns. While newspapers, magazines, and television used to be the primary sources, people now access news through websites, blogs, social media, and mobile apps. This shift has allowed for personalised news consumption, with individuals selecting the sources and timing that suit them best.

4.3.1 Digital Ecosystem and Media

The digital ecosystem shapes the media landscape, influencing how information is created, distributed, and consumed.

Interconnected Platforms: The digital ecosystem comprises various interconnected platforms, including websites, social media networks, streaming services, and mobile applications. These platforms facilitate the creation, sharing, and consumption of media content.

Accessibility and Global Reach: Digital platforms provide widespread accessibility to media content, breaking down geographical barriers. Users can access news, articles, videos, and other media from anywhere worldwide, enabling a global reach for creators and audiences.

Data-driven Insights: The digital ecosystem generates vast amounts of data through user interactions and behaviours. Media organisations leverage this data to gain insights into audience preferences, consumption patterns, and engagement metrics. These insights help shape content strategies and personalised user experiences.

Audience Participation: Digital media platforms encourage active audience participation. Users can comment on articles, share their opinions on social media, and engage in online discussions. This participatory aspect enhances the interactive nature of media and enables a sense of community among users.

Diversification of Content: The digital ecosystem allows for the diversification of media content. Traditional forms of media, such as print and broadcast, coexist with newer formats like online articles, podcasts, videos, and live streaming. This diversity caters to different audience preferences and consumption habits.

Evolving Technologies: The digital ecosystem is continuously evolving, driven by technological advancements. Innovations like artificial intelligence, virtual reality, and augmented reality are reshaping the media landscape, opening new possibilities for storytelling and audience engagement.

4.3.2 Journalism in the Age of Digital Media

The advent of digital media has revolutionised the practice of journalism, transforming the way news is produced, consumed, and shared.

Instantaneous News Dissemination: Digital media enables real-time news dissemination, allowing journalists to share updates instantly through websites, social media platforms, and mobile applications. This immediacy ensures that breaking news reaches the audience swiftly, fostering a culture of up-to-the-minute reporting. Journalists covering significant events like elections or natural disasters can share live updates, photos, and videos on social media platforms, informing the public in real-time.

Citizen Journalism and User-Generated Content: Digital media empowers individuals to participate in the news creation process through citizen journalism and user-generated content. Ordinary people can capture and share news-related content, such as photos, videos, or eyewitness accounts, providing unique perspectives and supplementing traditional reporting. During protests or public rallies, citizens often use their smartphones to record videos or capture photos, which are then shared on social media platforms, giving rise to citizen journalism.

Multimedia Storytelling: Digital media allows journalists to tell stories using various multimedia elements, including text, images, audio, and video. They can incorporate interactive features, infographics, and immersive experiences, enhancing audience engagement and understanding. Journalists covering a cultural event can create a multimedia package that includes interviews, photographs, and audio recordings, providing a more comprehensive and immersive storytelling experience.

Data Journalism and Visualisation: Digital media facilitates data journalism, where journalists analyse and present data-driven stories. They use visualisations, interactive charts, and infographics to simplify complex information, making it more accessible and engaging for the audience. Journalists investigating social and economic issues can collect data, analyse trends, and present their findings through interactive visualisations that help the audience grasp the significance of the data.

Audience Interaction and Feedback: Digital media encourages audience interaction and feedback, fostering two-way communication between journalists and readers. Readers can express their opinions and engage in discussions through comments, shares, and likes on social media or dedicated comment sections. Journalists can use social media platforms to ask readers for their views on specific topics or to gather firsthand accounts, enriching their reporting with diverse perspectives.

4.3.3 Society in the Digital World

The digital world has profoundly impacted society, influencing how people interact, communicate, and access information:

Connectivity and Communication: The digital world has brought people closer by facilitating instant and widespread communication. Social media

platforms, messaging apps, and video conferencing tools have transformed how individuals connect and interact with one another. Platforms like WhatsApp and Facebook have enabled Indians from different regions to stay connected, share updates, and engage in conversations, bridging geographical distances.

Access to Information and Education: The digital world has democratised access to information and education. With the availability of the Internet and online learning platforms, individuals in India can access a wealth of knowledge, educational resources, and online courses. Students from remote areas of India can access online educational platforms like Khan Academy or Coursera to enhance their learning opportunities and acquire new skills.

Digital Empowerment: The digital world has empowered individuals by providing them with platforms to voice their opinions, advocate for social issues, and participate in civic engagement. Social media has become a powerful tool for mobilising communities and driving social change. Indian citizens have utilised social media platforms to organise movements, raise awareness about social causes, and demand accountability from the government.

Privacy and Security Concerns: The digital world has raised privacy and data security concerns. With the increased sharing of personal information online, individuals need to be cautious about protecting their privacy and understanding the implications of their digital footprint. Instances of data breaches or privacy violations in India, such as unauthorised access to personal data or misuse of information, have raised awareness about the importance of digital privacy and security.

While the digital world has brought numerous benefits, it has highlighted the digital divide within Indian society. Access to digital technologies, internet connectivity, and digital literacy remains unequal, creating disparities between urban and rural areas and marginalised communities. The digital divide refers to the gap between those who have access to modern technology like computers and the Internet and those who don't or have limited access. It is influenced by and contributes to other social and economic inequalities. This divide can be seen in both rural and urban areas of India.

Here are some examples of the digital divide:

Socioeconomic Divide: India's existing social and economic disparities are the leading cause of the vast digital divide. This divide is present in both rural and urban areas.

Gender Divide: Unequal access to digital resources based on gender is still an issue in India. It is vital to address this divide and ensure that everyone can benefit from digital advancements.

Rural-Urban Divide: The digital divide often exists between people living in cities and those in rural areas. Despite the availability of electronic devices and internet services, this gap persists. Rural areas in India may have limited access to reliable internet connectivity, hindering their ability to fully participate in the digital world and access its benefits.

Lack of Access to Digital Technology: Developing countries, including India, face a digital divide due to limited access to technology and the Internet. This divide can also include a lack of digital skills and knowledge.

4.3.4 Case Studies of Digital Journalism

Khabar Lahariya: Khabar Lahariya is a news organisation founded in 2002 by Kavita Devi and Meera Javav in Chitrakoot, Uttar Pradesh, India. It focuses on sharing stories from rural India, particularly those concerning women. Khabar Lahariya is known for its commitment to empowering rural women and shedding light on their experiences.

The organisation's name, Khabar Lahariya, means "news wave" in Hindi. This reflects its mission to provide news and information to underserved rural communities. All of Khabar Lahariya's reporters are women who draw from their own experiences to share stories often ignored by mainstream media.

Khabar Lahariya has received several awards for its exceptional journalism, including the Ramnath Goenka Award for Excellence, the Chameli Devi Jain Award for Outstanding Women in Journalism, and the Kurt Schork Award for International Journalism. It has also gained recognition from international publications like The New York Times and The Guardian.

Boom Live: Boom Live is a mobile-first news app launched in 2015. It is a for-profit organisation that is funded by advertising. Boom Live has a team of over 50 journalists who produce content in Hindi and English. Boom Live has been praised for its use of technology and its commitment to delivering news promptly and engagingly.

How Boom Live Uses Technology to Deliver News:

Live video: Boom Live offers live video coverage of breaking news events. This allows users to watch the news unfold as it happens.

Interactive infographics: Boom Live uses interactive infographics to tell stories visually appealingly. This makes news more engaging and easier to understand.

Personalised news feeds: Boom Live uses artificial intelligence to personalise news feeds for each user. This ensures that users see the news that is most relevant to them.

Activity - 2

Read a case study of any digital media you choose and note its journalistic functions.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit

Fill in the blanks:

1. Boom Live is a mobile-first news app that was launched in (2014/2015)
2. Khabar Lahariya is a news organisation founded in 2002 from (Chitrakoot/ Jhansi)
3. The digital ecosystem consists of various platforms (separated/ Interconnected)

4.4 JOURNALISM AND SOCIETY

Journalism plays a crucial role in society by promoting public enlightenment, informing the public, promoting transparency and accountability, and fighting against government corruption. Citizen journalism has gained popularity in recent years, allowing ordinary citizens to report on events and issues that are important to them. In today's digital age, journalism is evolving rapidly. The advent of the Internet and social media has democratised access to information, enabling citizen journalism and increasing public participation in news dissemination. However, it has also brought challenges, such as the spread of misinformation, the erosion of traditional business models, and the need to navigate the ethical complexities of reporting in the digital realm.

Journalism plays a crucial role in society. Here are some key points

4.4.1 Journalism and Society: A Symbiosis

Journalism and society are closely related, supporting each other's growth and progress.

Journalism acts as a mirror, reflecting society's realities, challenges, and dreams. It gives a voice to diverse individuals, sheds light on social issues, and raises awareness about marginalised perspectives. In India, journalism has played a vital role in addressing gender inequality, caste discrimination, and environmental concerns.

Journalism promotes democratic values by providing essential information for informed decision-making. It enables citizens to participate in the democratic process actively, ensuring transparency and accountability in governance. During elections in India, journalism is crucial in informing voters about political parties, candidates, and policies.

Journalism influences public opinion and shapes social discussions. Indian media outlets have influenced debates on sensitive issues like religious tensions, social justice, and human rights. Journalism can sway public sentiment and drive social change through reporting, analysis, and opinion pieces.

4.4.2 Changing Form of Journalism and Social Impact

Journalism in India has undergone a significant transformation in recent years, driven by the emergence of digital platforms and a shifting media landscape. Digital journalism has introduced new storytelling techniques,

including multimedia content, interactive articles, and data journalism. Online news outlets in India have embraced these innovative approaches, incorporating videos, infographics, and interactive elements to enhance audience engagement and understanding.

The advent of social media has made it easier for news and information to be shared, but it has also facilitated the spread of misinformation. Traditional news outlets have faced a decline, resulting in a decrease in the availability of high-quality journalism. Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram have played significant roles in disseminating news and promoting social movements in India, showcasing the power of digital journalism in shaping public discourse. Additionally, the increasing threat of censorship has posed challenges for journalists in performing their duties effectively.

The continued rise of social media will pose challenges for traditional news outlets. Journalists must explore innovative methods to reach a broader audience and find sustainable ways to monetise their content. With the decline of traditional news outlets, there may be a decrease in the availability of high-quality journalism. Consequently, supporting credible journalism becomes even more vital for the public. The growing threat of censorship will further complicate the work of journalists. Therefore, journalists must maintain their independence and diligently verify their sources.

The changing form of journalism in India has had a profound social impact, empowering marginalised communities to share their stories, raise awareness about social issues, and mobilise for change. Online campaigns and digital journalism have played pivotal roles in highlighting topics such as gender equality, LGBTQ+ rights, and environmental conservation. Moreover, the accessibility of digital journalism has democratised access to information, enabling people in remote areas of India to stay informed through digital news platforms on their smartphones. However, challenges have emerged alongside these advancements, including spreading misinformation, disrupting traditional business models, and concerns over privacy and data security. Journalists and media organisations in India face these challenges while upholding ethical standards and preserving public trust in the digital age.

4.4.3 Social Responsibility of Journalism

Journalism in India carries a significant social responsibility, as it is crucial in informing, educating, and empowering the public. Journalists are entrusted with the task of reporting news accurately, upholding ethical standards, and promoting democratic values. This set of detailed notes explores the social responsibility of journalism in India, highlighting its importance and providing relevant examples.

Informing and Educating the Public: Journalists are responsible for providing accurate and timely information to the public, enabling them to make informed decisions.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, journalists played a vital role in disseminating crucial information about the virus, preventive measures, and

vaccine updates, helping to educate the public and curb the spread of misinformation.

Promoting Transparency and Accountability: Journalists act as watchdogs, holding those in power accountable and exposing corruption or wrongdoing. Investigative journalists have exposed numerous scams, such as the 2G spectrum scam and the Commonwealth Games corruption scandal, leading to public outrage, legal actions, and calls for systemic reforms.

Giving Voice to the Marginalised: Journalists are responsible for amplifying marginalised communities' voices, giving them a platform to share their stories and concerns.

Journalists have highlighted the struggles and discrimination faced by Dalits, tribal communities, and other marginalised groups, bringing attention to their social issues and advocating for justice and equality.

Raising Awareness and Advocating for Social Issues: Journalists can play an instrumental role in raising awareness about pressing social issues, such as gender inequality, environmental degradation, and human rights violations. The media's coverage of the #MeToo movement in India shed light on widespread sexual harassment and assault, leading to a national dialogue, legal action against perpetrators, and increased awareness about workplace harassment.

Fostering Dialogue and Constructive Discourse: Journalists should facilitate meaningful conversations on important topics, encouraging diverse perspectives and promoting tolerance and understanding. Opinion pieces and panel discussions have provided platforms for experts and stakeholders to discuss contentious issues like religious tensions, social justice, and political ideologies, fostering dialogue and shaping public opinion.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit

1. How do Journalism and society have a symbiotic relationship?

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2. What are the social responsibilities of journalism?

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3. Write a note on the impact of changing the form of journalism.

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4.5 JOURNALISM, DIGITAL MEDIA AND SOCIETY

India, a vast and diverse nation, has a rich journalistic heritage. Indian journalists have played a significant role in the country's struggle for independence and evolution into a democratic government. Recently, they have encountered various obstacles, such as the surge of social media, the decline of traditional news platforms, and a growing threat of censorship. Nevertheless, amidst these challenges, India is fortunate to have numerous dedicated journalists who uphold high standards.

Society, in turn, is shaped by the interplay between journalism and digital media. The news and information we consume influence our perceptions, opinions, and behaviours, shaping public discourse and societal norms. Digital media's accessibility has provided individuals from diverse backgrounds with greater access to information, enabling engagement with news and participation in public debates. This has the potential to bridge social divides, foster inclusivity, and amplify the voices of marginalised communities. As technology advances and societal needs evolve, journalism and digital media must adapt to meet the demands of an increasingly interconnected and information-driven world, ensuring the continued vitality of an informed and engaged society.

4.5.1 Role of Digital Media in the Empowerment of Society

Digital media has emerged as a powerful tool in empowering society, particularly in recent years. It has revolutionised how information is disseminated, accessed, and shared, transforming society. In the Indian context, digital media has played a significant role in fostering empowerment and creating positive change across different spheres. Here are some recent examples that highlight the role of digital media in the empowerment of Indian society:

Social Movements and Activism: Digital media platforms, such as social networking sites and online communities, have provided a space for individuals and groups to voice their concerns and mobilise for social causes. The #MeToo movement in India, which gained momentum in 2018, witnessed survivors of sexual harassment using digital media to share their experiences, expose perpetrators, and demand justice. The movement empowered survivors, sparked a nationwide conversation on gender equality, and led to tangible changes in workplace policies.

Grassroots Journalism and Citizen Reporting: Digital media has democratised the field of journalism, enabling citizens to become active participants in news reporting. In recent years, citizen journalists in India have utilised social media platforms, blogs, and independent news websites to report on local issues, uncover corruption, and highlight social injustices.

For instance, during the devastating floods in Kerala in 2018, social media platforms served as crucial channels for citizens to share real-time updates, coordinate relief efforts, and seek assistance. This citizen-led reporting empowered communities and facilitated prompt responses from authorities.

Education and Knowledge Dissemination: Digital media has revolutionised access to education and knowledge-sharing in India. Online learning platforms, educational apps, and open educational resources have made quality education accessible to remote areas and marginalised communities. For example, the National Digital Library of India provides free access to many academic resources, books, and research materials, empowering students and researchers with valuable information irrespective of their geographical location or economic background.

Social Entrepreneurship and Economic Empowerment: Digital media has facilitated the growth of social entrepreneurship and enabled individuals to create economic opportunities for themselves and their communities. Online marketplaces and platforms like Etsy, Amazon, and social media business pages have allowed artisans, craftsmen, and small-scale entrepreneurs in India to showcase and sell their products to a global audience. This digital presence has opened new markets, increased income generation, and empowered individuals to pursue sustainable livelihoods.

Political Engagement and Participatory Democracy: Digital media has significantly increased political engagement and fostered participatory democracy in India. Social media platforms have allowed citizens to express their political opinions, engage with political leaders, and participate in public discourse. Platforms like Twitter and Facebook have facilitated direct interactions between citizens and policymakers, enabling them to voice their concerns, hold elected officials accountable, and influence policy decisions.

Women's Empowerment: Social media platforms have proven to be a powerful tool for promoting women's empowerment in India. Platforms like Twitter and Facebook have allowed women to share their experiences, connect with others, and raise awareness about issues such as gender violence and discrimination. The #MeToo movement originated in the United States and gained significant momentum in India through social media. This movement helped break the silence surrounding sexual harassment and assault, leading to the prosecution of several high-profile offenders.

This illustrates how digital media has empowered Indian society across various domains, including social activism, journalism, education, entrepreneurship, and political engagement.

4.5.2 Future of Journalism in the Age of Digital Media

The future of journalism in the age of digital media is a topic that has been hotly debated in recent years. Some experts believe digital media will spell the end of traditional journalism, while others believe it will simply change how journalism is done.

The landscape of journalism is rapidly evolving in the digital media age, presenting challenges and opportunities for the future. Digital media has

disrupted traditional news production, distribution, and consumption models, reshaping how journalism operates in India and worldwide.

Digital Transformation and Convergence: Digital media has transformed how news organisations operate, forcing them to adapt to the changing landscape. Legacy media outlets are now embracing digital platforms to reach wider audiences and engage with readers in new ways. For example, leading Indian newspapers such as The Times of India and The Hindustan Times have established robust online platforms, offering multimedia content, interactive features, and real-time updates to cater to the preferences of digital-savvy readers.

Rise of Data Journalism: In the era of big data, journalism is increasingly incorporating data-driven storytelling. Data journalism involves analysing and visualising large datasets to uncover meaningful insights and present them in an easily understandable format. Indian news organisations, like The Quint and IndiaSpend, have embraced data journalism to investigate and report on diverse topics ranging from politics and governance to social issues, adding depth and context to news stories.

Citizen Journalism and User-Generated Content: Digital media has actively empowered citizens to participate in news production and dissemination. Social media platforms have become avenues for citizen journalists to capture and share real-time news events.

Multimedia Storytelling: Digital media enables journalists to tell stories using various formats, including text, images, videos, podcasts, and interactive elements. Multimedia storytelling enhances the audience's engagement and understanding of complex issues.

Audience Engagement and Personalisation: Digital media allows for direct engagement with audiences, enabling journalists to interact with readers and involve them in the news process. News organisations use social media, comment sections, and interactive features to facilitate conversations and gather feedback. The Indian news platform, The Print, actively encourages reader engagement through comments, social media interactions, and live discussions, fostering a sense of community and co-creation of news.

Fact-Checking and Combating Misinformation: In the age of social media, combating misinformation has become crucial. News organisations and fact-checking initiatives like Boom Live in India are dedicated to verifying and debunking false information that circulates online.

Monetisation and Business Models: As traditional revenue streams decline, news organisations explore innovative business models to sustain quality journalism. This includes subscription-based models, paywalls, sponsored content, and partnerships with other organisations.

4.5.3 Impact of Digital Journalism on Society: Case Studies

Case Study 1: The Nirbhaya Case and the Power of Digital Journalism

One significant case that highlights the impact of digital journalism on Indian society is the Nirbhaya case, which occurred in 2012. Nirbhaya, a pseudonym

given to a young woman, was brutally gang-raped and fatally assaulted in New Delhi. This horrific incident sparked nationwide outrage and protests demanding justice for the victim and seeking systemic changes to address gender violence.

Digital journalism played a pivotal role in amplifying the voices of the protesters and shedding light on the case. Social media platforms like Twitter and Facebook became crucial channels for citizen journalists, activists, and concerned citizens to share real-time updates, organise protests, and raise awareness. Hashtags like #Nirbhaya and #JusticeForNirbhaya trended, facilitating widespread dissemination of information and mobilising public support.

Digital news outlets and independent journalists were vital in investigating and reporting the case. They provided in-depth coverage, shared victim testimonials, and exposed the systemic failures that allowed such a heinous crime to occur. Digital media outlets also published opinion pieces and analyses, fueling public discourse and debates on issues like gender violence, safety, and legal reform.

The impact of digital journalism in the Nirbhaya case was profound. It contributed to public outrage, placing pressure on the government and judicial system to ensure swift and fair justice. The case led to significant legal reforms, including the amendment of laws related to sexual assault and the establishment of fast-track courts for handling such cases. It also sparked a broader conversation about gender equality and safety in India, increasing awareness and efforts to address systemic issues.

Case Study 2: The Assam floods

In May 2022, Assam was hit by devastating floods. The floods displaced millions of people and caused widespread damage. Various factors, including heavy rains, overflowing rivers, and poor drainage, caused the floods.

Digital media played a significant role in raising awareness of the floods and mobilising aid. Platforms like Twitter and Facebook were used to spread information about the floods, raise money, and connect with affected people.

One of the most notable examples of how digital media was used to raise awareness of the floods was the #AssamFloods hashtag. The hashtag was used by thousands of people to share information about the floods, to offer support to those affected, and to demand action from the government.

The hashtag was also used to raise money for relief efforts. Several organisations, including the Red Cross and UNICEF, set up crowdfunding campaigns on platforms like GoFundMe. These campaigns raised millions of dollars to help those affected by the floods.

Digital media was also used to connect people affected by the floods. Platforms like Twitter and Facebook were used to create groups and forums where people could share information, offer support, and find help.

The role of digital media in the Assam floods of 2022 shows how digital media can be used to raise awareness of important issues, mobilise aid, and

connect people affected by disasters.

4.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, we have understood how the media is a vehicle to carry information from the source to the public. Digital media is an innovation in the exact vehicle with some astonishing features attracting people nowadays. Journalism is the profession which feeds media. Journalism and digital media have a combined influence on society and vice versa. Digital media cannot be thought of without the Internet today, and society as a whole cannot be considered without the Internet and digital media. So, this unit tried to unravel the relationship between journalism, digital media and society.

We also discussed in this unit how the facet of journalism changed, how digital media emerged and thrived in a different ecosystem and what role they played in influencing society or getting influenced by it.

4.8 FURTHER READINGS

Lindgren, Simon (2021), Digital Media and Society, Sage, UK.

Jebril, Nael; Jukes, Stephen; Iordanidou, Sofia; Takas, Emmanouil (2020), Journalism, Society and Politics in the Digital Media Era, Intellect Books, UK.

Orellano, Jericka (2017), Digital Media and Communication, Delve Publishing, Canada

4.9 KEYWORDS

Digital Divide: Access to digital technologies, internet connectivity, and digital literacy remains unequal, creating disparities between urban and rural areas and marginalised communities. This is called the digital divide.

Socioeconomic Divide: India's existing social and economic disparities are the leading cause of the vast digital divide. This divide is present in both rural and urban areas.

Gender Divide: Unequal access to digital resources based on gender is still an issue in India. It is called the Gender divide.

Rural-Urban Divide: The digital divide often exists between people living in cities and those in rural areas. Despite the availability of electronic devices and internet services, this gap persists. Rural areas in India may have limited access to reliable internet connectivity, hindering their ability to fully participate in the digital world and access its benefits.

4.7 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. False

2. True
3. True

Check Your Progress 2

1. 2015
2. Chitrakoot
3. Interconnected

Check Your Progress 3

1. Journalism and society are closely related, supporting each other's growth and progress. Journalism acts as a mirror, reflecting society's realities, challenges, and dreams. It gives a voice to diverse individuals, sheds light on social issues, and raises awareness about marginalised perspectives. In India, journalism has played a vital role in addressing gender inequality, caste discrimination, and environmental concerns.
2. Informing and Educating the Public, Promoting Transparency and Accountability, Giving Voice to the Marginalised, Raising Awareness and Advocating for Social Issues, Fostering Dialogue and Constructive Discourse
3. The changing form of journalism in India has had a profound social impact, empowering marginalised communities to share their stories, raise awareness about social issues, and mobilise for change. Online campaigns and digital journalism have played pivotal roles in highlighting topics such as gender equality, LGBTQ+ rights, and environmental conservation. Moreover, the accessibility of digital journalism has democratised access to information, enabling people in remote areas of India to stay informed through digital news platforms on their smartphones.